



GOAL AREA 5

Every child has access to
inclusive social protection and
lives free from poverty

Global Annual
Results Report 2024

unicef 
for every child

Cover image: © UNICEF/UNI431599/Sokhin
Rehana Bibi, 36, sitting inside a tent with her children (from left to right): Muskan, 8, Aisha, 3, and Ghazal, 14. The tent became family's temporary shelter after their house in Geokaloi Village, Sindh Province was flooded.

Between June and October 2022, floods in Pakistan claimed the lives of 1,739 individuals. These floods were primarily triggered by abnormally heavy monsoon rains and glacial melt following an intense heatwave, all of which are interconnected with the effects of climate change.

In Sindh, a devastating flood event claimed the lives of 799 individuals and left 8,422 injured, with 338 of them being children. This catastrophe led to the displacement of a staggering 10 million people in Sindh, and it wreaked havoc on 57,496 homes, primarily within the Hyderabad Division. Additionally, an extensive area of 6,200 square kilometers of farmland was inundated and destroyed by the floodwaters.

Expression of thanks: © UNICEF/UNI594452/Dejongh
Elvira, a 28-year-old woman with her son, in the village of Otoxha, in the south of Belize.

Omarion and his 28-year-old wife Emeldina have 2 children.

The family benefits also from the ROVEN cash program.

Through the ROVEN cash program they receive 100 US dollars every month for 6 months. "With this money we buy rice, flour and beans. We also teach the children. It helps us enormously," says Alberto.

UNICEF's social protection program supported the implementation of a nutrition-based cash transfer program in this village.



Expression of thanks

UNICEF is funded through the voluntary support of millions of people around the world and our partners in government, civil society and the private sector. Voluntary contributions enable UNICEF to deliver on its mandate to protect children's rights, help to meet their basic needs and expand their opportunities to reach their full potential. UNICEF takes this opportunity to thank all partners for their commitment and trust.

UNICEF expresses its gratitude to partners supporting core Goal Area 5 resource envelopes, including contributions to the Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Pool. Thematic funding provides flexibility for long-term planning, bolsters the sustainability of programmes, and allows UNICEF to invest in innovative and new approaches. Contributions from the Government of Spain and UNICEF National Committees in Germany and Portugal were instrumental in addressing the emerging needs and challenges of children, particularly in child poverty reduction and the expansion of inclusive social protection. This support focused on seven countries: Colombia, Costa Rica, Ethiopia, Jordan, Morocco, the Philippines and Sierra Leone.

In 2024, the European Commission, the Government of Germany and the German state-owned investment and development bank (KfW), the World Bank, the United Nations Multi-Partner Trust Fund and the International Labour Organization contributed critical support to Goal Area 5 through their non-thematic window. In addition, Danish, United Kingdom and United States private sector partners also contributed critical country-specific allocations in support of vital, game-changing interventions to reduce child poverty. UNICEF is grateful to the governments of Belgium, Iceland, Ireland and Sweden for their critical support to this area of work and in particular for their continuous commitment and support to realize the right of every child to social protection.

Some 79 years after UNICEF was established and 36 years since the adoption of the Convention on the Rights of the Child, the organization's mission to promote the full attainment of the rights of all children is as urgent as ever. UNICEF's continued efforts have led to significant investments in Goal Area 5, reducing child poverty and bolstering social protection systems in all contexts, expanding humanitarian cash transfer programmes both through the use of national systems and the UNICEF direct delivery system, and catalysing crucial public and private sector commitments to child-sensitive policies. Working with governments at national and subnational levels, United Nations partners, International Financial Institutions, the private sector and civil society – and with the full participation of children and adolescents – UNICEF remains steadfast in its commitment to reversing critical setbacks in child poverty and realizing the rights of all children, everywhere, for a world in which no child is left behind.

The following report summarizes the results achieved by UNICEF and its partners under Goal Area 5 in 2024. This report is one of five Global Annual Results Reports on the results of efforts during the past year, 'Every child survives and thrives', 'Every child learns', 'Every child is protected from violence and exploitation', 'Every child lives in a safe and clean environment' and 'Every child has access to inclusive social protection and lives free from poverty'. It supplements the 2024 Executive Director Annual Report.



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Three children of Ms. Fatma Nur who live in a village of Kahramanmaraş and benefit from UNICEF's Cash Transfer Program.

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Abbreviations and Acronyms

CFCI:	Child-Friendly Cities Initiative	ODA:	Official development assistance
EU:	European Union	OECD:	Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development
FFD4:	4th Financing for Development	PF4C:	Public Finance for Children
KfW:	Kreditanstalt für Wiederaufbau	POFP:	President's Office Finance and Planning
GA:	Goal Area	SDGs:	Sustainable Development Goals
G20:	Group of 20	SPIAC-B:	Social Protection Inter-Agency Cooperation Board
HOPE:	Humanitarian cash Operations and Programme Ecosystem	UNDP:	United Nations Development Programme
ILO:	International Labour Organization	UNDESA:	United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs
IMF:	International Monetary Fund	UNHCR:	United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees
INFF:	Integrated National Financing Framework	UNICEF:	United Nations Children's Fund
MENA:	Middle East and North Africa	WFP:	World Food Programme
MICS:	The Multiple Indicator Cluster Surveys		
NSNP:	National Safety Net Programme		
OBS:	Open Budget Survey		



Executive Summary

August 15, 2023, Odesa, Ukraine.

Tetiana (57), a mother-educator from Beryslav, with her adopted children at their temporary home in Odesa.

Tetiana, has ten children, including seven she has adopted. Like millions, when the full-scale war broke out in Ukraine last February, their world turned upside down.

For nine months, the family were unable to flee the Khersonska region, due to the fighting. But as soon as it became possible, they packed their bags – shelling had intensified, a military plane had crashed near the house and unexploded shells were lying right in the yard. Furthermore, there was no gas, electricity or water.

To Tetiana's relief, the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) provided the family with the financial assistance they needed to settle in their new home. Part of the money was also spent on taking the children on a vacation in the Carpathians, where they spent time getting the health treatment they needed as part of a social programme.

The Spilno Cash assistance programme is implemented by UNICEF, with funding provided by the European Union, the governments of Portugal, Norway and Germany through the German Federal Foreign Office (GFFO) and the Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ) GmbH, and the family of UNICEF National Committees. August 15, 2023, Odesa, Ukraine.

UNICEF's Goal Area 5 (GA5) is intended to ensure that every child, including adolescents, has access to inclusive social protection and lives free from poverty. In 2024, UNICEF focused on GA5, spending US\$0.82 billion across 155 countries, with US\$574 million allocated for humanitarian action. These efforts aimed to combat child poverty through investments in social protection systems and social sectors to tackle multiple deprivations, and by expanding humanitarian cash transfers and encouraging public and private sector commitments to child-sensitive policies. These initiatives were designed to support vulnerable populations, such as children with disabilities, by creating sustainable frameworks that address their basic needs and reduce poverty.

UNICEF continued to drive global advocacy for addressing child poverty, emphasizing the need for policy action to meet poverty reduction targets. It highlighted the visibility of children living in poverty through global forums and launched resources on policy solutions. UNICEF's advocacy also focused on vulnerable groups, such as girls and children with disabilities, while also addressing the impact of climate change and other crises on impoverished children, in collaboration with various partners.

Through its Public Finance for Children (PF4C) initiative, UNICEF promoted a child-centred financing agenda aimed at improving resource allocation, fiscal equity and public participation. This initiative ensured that public finance strategies aligned with children's rights and advocated for adequate resource allocation in critical sectors including education, health and child protection, to tackle multidimensional child poverty. UNICEF's work in this area contributed to greater equity in access to services for marginalized children, fostering improvements in fiscal systems globally.

Additionally, UNICEF focused on expanding and strengthening social protection systems, ensuring their inclusivity and addressing the needs of vulnerable groups. It worked on integrating gender-responsive and disability-inclusive policies, and advocated for shock-responsive, multisectoral systems to meet the unique needs of children, women and marginalized populations. Through these efforts, UNICEF aimed to improve access to essential services and supported policies that reduce gender inequality and empower families.

UNICEF effectively addressed both immediate and long-term challenges faced by children in conflict and crisis. In 2024, it leveraged its technical expertise to deliver humanitarian cash transfers, meeting urgent needs in fragile contexts. UNICEF employed risk-informed strategies to ensure that essential services such as health care, education and child protection were accessible to vulnerable families, ultimately building resilience in crisis-affected regions. Through both national systems and direct delivery, UNICEF ensured timely, needs-based support to those most in need.

Lastly, considering the critical role of family-friendly policies and universal access to social services such as childcare, education and nutrition services for reducing child poverty and inequities, UNICEF supported targeted and tailored approaches to reach the most marginalized children and families with initiatives such as subsidized and affordable childcare for working parents, free school meals and nutrition-sensitive cash transfers. Putting this into practice involved twin-track approaches that promote increased coverage of mainstream interventions to improve outcomes for all children, while incorporating tailored and differentiated strategies to meet the needs of children with disabilities.

Despite the growing geopolitical and economic fragmentation that pose serious threats to children's rights, ending child poverty in the twenty-first century is within our power. In 2025, in an increasingly constrained resource environment characterized by shrinking Official Development Assistance and short-term and earmarked contributions, UNICEF will amplify its efforts under GA5 while shifting its focus towards equitable public social sector investment and stronger cooperation with governments and local actors, underpinned by a reinvigorated commitment to uphold child rights and put children at the centre of all policymaking. This can drive the kind of progress that enables more children than ever before to realize their rights to live free of poverty and access inclusive social protection.

Highlights of major breakthroughs in 2024

- ✓ Implementing universal child allowances, child grants and family benefits such as parental leave to reduce child poverty and yield wider social and economic benefits
- ✓ Placing the situation of children living in poverty high on global, regional and national agendas – and the policy solutions to tackle multiple deprivations, with specific focus on reaching children with disabilities and girls
- ✓ Child rights promotion through more equitable budget allocation and investments for children in social sectors
- ✓ Universal access to social services and family-friendly policies that address exclusion for families of children with disabilities
- ✓ Promoting child-friendly frameworks within local government systems to integrate children's rights into policies and planning
- ✓ Provision of flexible and effective cash-based assistance in humanitarian settings, empowering families to meet their immediate needs and build resilience in the face of crises
- ✓ Integration of face recognition technology into UNICEF's HOPE data system to improve the accuracy and speed of deduplication, ensuring unique personal records and enabling more efficient cash assistance delivery in humanitarian settings.



Children play at one of the schools turned into shelters in Khan Younis city, southern Gaza Strip.



Strategic context

Displaced children and families at their newfound refuge at a primary school in Kassala state.

Now in its second year, the war in Sudan continues to keep children and families in displacement. Sudan is now the largest child displacement crisis in the world.

Additionally, the conflict in Sudan is severely putting at risk the health and well-being of Sudan's 24 million children, therewith the future of the country and heavily affecting the wider region. 14 million children in Sudan require urgent humanitarian assistance.

Progress in child poverty reduction has decelerated in recent years. Globally, nearly a billion children live in multidimensional poverty and 333 million children live in extreme poverty, struggling to survive on less than US\$2.15 per day, with extreme child poverty being increasingly concentrated in sub-Saharan Africa.¹ More than 800 million children survive on less than US\$3.65/day.² Today's children are twice as likely as adults to live in poverty. The impacts of poverty on children are both immediate and lifelong – heightening rights violations such as child labour and child marriage and diminishing children's aspirations and opportunities to thrive. This unrealized human potential has inevitable adverse and long-term implications for the child, communities, societies and economies.

The intertwined crises of economic instability, climate disasters and ongoing conflicts have pushed millions of families to the brink, deepening inequalities and limiting access to essential services.³ Childhood poverty increases children's exposure and vulnerability to extreme weather events; at the same time, climate shocks heighten the probability of children living in multidimensional poverty.⁴

Governments, constrained by fiscal pressures and rising debt burdens, struggle to fund the essential services that children need to survive and thrive.⁵ Critical financing gaps in child social services, including health (US\$513 per capita), education (US\$281 per child) and social assistance (US\$66 per capita), threaten children's rights, while humanitarian contexts face additional challenges with inadequate preparedness and response funding.⁶ This situation is further complicated by climate finance discussions that often overlook social sectors and children's rights, particularly affecting vulnerable groups like girls, children with disabilities and those living in poverty, highlighting the urgent need for increased, equitable and early-stage social investments.

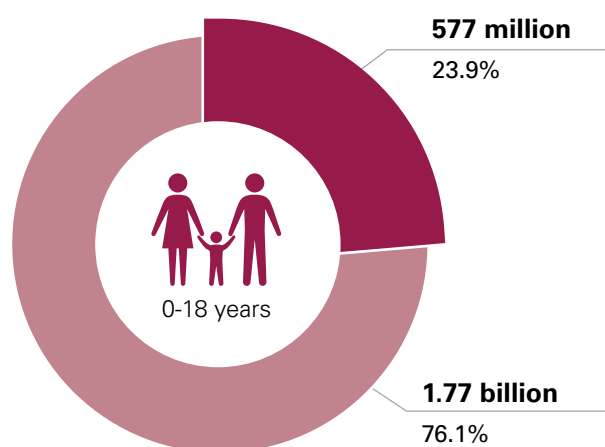
Global humanitarian needs increased significantly in 2024, with nearly 300 million people needing humanitarian assistance due to conflict, climate-related disasters and economic challenges. One in five children globally lives in or is fleeing conflict.⁷ Around 38.6 per cent of children who live in countries affected by conflict and fragility live in extremely poor households, compared to 10 per cent of children in non-fragile states. Despite children comprising 30 per cent of the global population, they are significantly represented (i.e., 40 per cent of all forcibly displaced people are children) among the forcibly displaced population.⁸ Children continue to be particularly affected, with millions facing severe food insecurity, malnutrition and limited access to essential services.⁹ Girls and women have been disproportionately impacted by multiple crises. Enhancing

social protection systems in fragile and humanitarian contexts is crucial to upholding the rights of children and halting the acceleration in child poverty triggered by crises.

The positive impacts of social protection for children are beyond question. Extensive evidence shows that child-sensitive social protection reduces poverty by contributing to income security in households, while also having broader significance for child health, education and food security and protection. Further, it provides resilience for households, allowing them to boost their productivity and earning potential, and lowers the risk of the intergenerational transmission of poverty. All 2.4 billion children in the world need social protection to be healthy and happy and realize their full potential.

However, despite the clear and overwhelming impact of social protection across multiple outcomes for children, women and families, as well as its role in addressing climate and other risks, unacceptable gaps persist in the coverage and adequacy of social protection. According to the latest data on Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) indicator 1.3.1,^a while for the first time, more than half of the global population (52.4 per cent) has some form of social protection coverage, only 23.9 per cent of children aged 0–18 years are covered, leaving the remaining 76.1 per cent, or 1.77 billion children, unprotected and vulnerable to poverty, exclusion and multidimensional deprivations (see Figure 1).¹⁰

FIGURE 1. Family and child benefits



^a SDG Indicator 1.3.1 focuses on measuring the proportion of the population covered by social protection systems, including floors, ensuring access for all people, particularly the poor and vulnerable, in line with national definitions. Source: United Nations, Sustainable Development Goals, <<https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/metadata/files/Metadata-01-03-01a.pdf>>, accessed 12 May 2025.

Children represent nearly half of the total population without social protection coverage. However, this global average coverage hides significant disparities across regions and population groups. Low-income and low- and middle-income countries have much lower rates of coverage (9.7 per cent in low-income countries). Children with disabilities or living in a household with a family member with a disability are more vulnerable to poverty and face financial barriers to a full life but are less likely to receive adequate social protection. As the world confronts uncertain times, with slow economic growth, political instability and an ever-evolving climate crisis, protecting and expanding social protection coverage and strengthening systems is more than ever an essential, strategic investment to end child poverty, foster social inclusion and expand children's opportunities to reach their full potential.

Climate change, increasing fragility and conflict, displacement and heightened vulnerabilities due to shifts in the global political landscape have collectively strained social protection systems worldwide. Social protection remains underfunded and vulnerable to competing priorities, due to challenges at the intersection of political

will, fiscal constraints and financing difficulties. The reduction in official development assistance (ODA) and the burden of debt have further limited the capacity of governments to fund and sustain robust social protection systems. As a result, government budget cuts to social sectors in several countries have led to a reduction in social protection coverage, including child benefits. This situation is severely undermining social protection systems, making it difficult to provide consistent and adequate support to vulnerable populations.

Goal Area 5 under UNICEF's Strategic Plan 2022–2025 is intended to ensure that every child, including adolescents, has access to inclusive social protection and lives free from poverty. UNICEF's commitments under this area of work support the realization of the right to social security and the right to an adequate standard of living, as set out in the Convention on the Rights of the Child, while also supporting acceleration of progress across child-specific SDGs, particularly 1 and 10 (see Figure 2). Reaching these SDG child poverty targets by 2030 requires extraordinary, concerted commitment, investment and action at subnational, national, regional and global levels.

FIGURE 2. Sustainable Development Goals 1 and 10





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Goal Area 5: A life free of poverty and inclusive social protection

On 25 September 2024, pregnant women and lactating mothers are enrolled on UNICEF's Mother and Child Cash Transfer Plus (MCCT+) an integrated social protection programme in River Nile state.

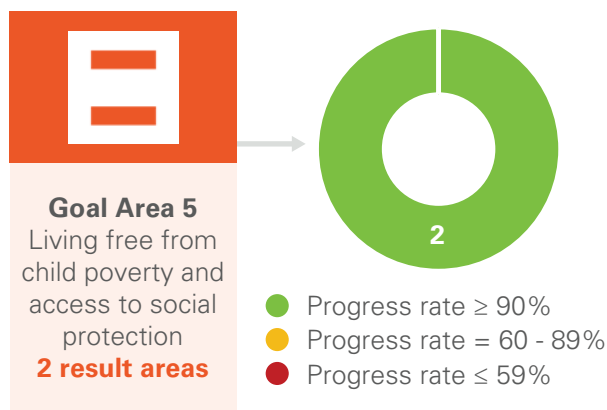
The programme that supports pregnant and lactating women and their infants and young children during the first 1,000 days of life—a critical window for optimal growth and development.

Once enrolled in the programme, women receive quarterly cash payments along with antenatal and postnatal care, nutrition services for their children, child protection and other essential services until their child reaches two years of age.

The programme currently benefits 78,000 women across 12 localities in the two eastern states of Kassala and Red Sea, and it will be expanded to reach an additional 15,000 women in two localities in River Nile state. MCCT+ helps reduce maternal and child mortality, prevent malnutrition among children and women, and empowers women and families to care for themselves and their children.

In 2024, UNICEF worked on Goal Area 5 in 155 countries, with a total expenditure of US\$0.82 billion, including US\$574 million for humanitarian action. UNICEF efforts led to significant investments in Goal Area 5, bolstering social protection systems in all contexts, expanding humanitarian cash transfer programmes and catalysing crucial public and private sector commitments to child-sensitive policies, with the aim of bringing an end to child poverty (see Figure 3).

FIGURE 3. Goal Area 5 progress, 2024



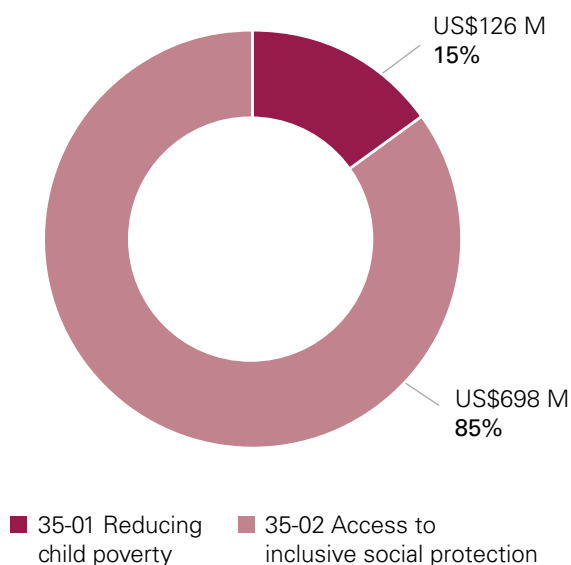
UNICEF continues to drive global advocacy to highlight the urgent need to address child poverty. In 2024, UNICEF focused on elevating the visibility of children living in poverty and emphasized the need for policy action to meet global poverty reduction targets. UNICEF played a key thought leadership role via global forums, launched major assets on policy solutions for child poverty reduction, and advocated for social protection programmes to address the needs of vulnerable groups, such as girls and children with disabilities. Collaborating with partners, UNICEF also focused on the impact of climate change and other crises on children living in poverty.

UNICEF's Public Finance for Children (PF4C) work in 2024 advanced a child-centred financing agenda, promoting better resource allocation, enhanced efficiency, fiscal equity and greater public participation, all aimed at improving the well-being of children globally. The PF4C initiative also played an active role in global financing discussions, particularly through its partnerships with organizations including the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) and United Nations Department of Economic and Social Affairs (UNDESA). UNICEF ensured that public finance strategies are aligned with children's rights and advocated for the allocation of adequate resources to critical sectors such as education, health, social protection and child protection. This focus contributed to more equitable access to services for marginalized children and improved fiscal equity.

UNICEF also focused on expanding the coverage of social protection, strengthening its systems and ensuring the inclusion of vulnerable populations through integrated and inclusive programmes. Efforts were directed at enhancing the scope and adequacy of child benefits, disability-inclusive programmes and gender-responsive policies. UNICEF collaborated with governments and partners to design and implement shock-responsive, multisectoral systems that address the unique needs of children, women and marginalized groups. This included promoting family-friendly policies, linking social protection to essential services such as education and health, and advancing care systems. UNICEF supported capacity-building for social protection actors and facilitated the digitalization of information management systems, ensuring greater transparency and efficiency. Additionally, UNICEF worked to integrate displaced populations into national social protection frameworks and fostered policies that support unpaid care work, empowering families and reducing gender inequality.

UNICEF is uniquely positioned to address both immediate and long-term challenges faced by children in conflict and crisis. By leveraging its technical and operational expertise, in 2024 UNICEF effectively delivered humanitarian cash transfers, improving outcomes for children in fragile contexts. Focusing on risk-informed strategies, UNICEF removed financial barriers to essential services, meeting urgent humanitarian needs at scale while building resilience. Through its multisectoral mandate and using both national systems and direct delivery, UNICEF ensured vulnerable children and families receive immediate support in nutrition, health care, education, water, sanitation and child protection. UNICEF delivered cash assistance through both national systems and direct delivery, ensuring timely, needs-based support.

FIGURE 4. Goal Area 5 expenses in 2024 by result area (total for UNICEF)



Reducing child poverty

Child poverty remains a cornerstone of UNICEF's mission and agenda, rooted in the Convention on the Rights of the Child and the right of every child to a quality standard of living, and access to education, nutrition, water, sanitation and health services. In 2024, UNICEF solidified its position as the foremost advocate for children living in poverty, highlighting the critical need for immediate action at global, regional and national levels to tackle child poverty. At the global level, UNICEF engaged in key policy fora and with strategic partners to elevate both the visibility of children living in poverty, with a specific focus on particular groups of children vulnerable to poverty, such as children with disabilities, and the urgency to advance effective policies in reducing multidimensional and monetary child poverty. This included bringing urgent attention to the fact that child poverty reduction has decelerated globally, with over 300 million children in extreme poverty and nearly 1 billion children in multidimensional poverty. At the current rate, the SDG poverty targets are severely off track. To increase recognition of the urgency of tackling and ending child poverty, UNICEF developed a global/regional child poverty advocacy strategy in 2024. Key advocacy pillars of the strategy include coalescing a coalition of champion countries and increased focus on evidence-based advocacy, highlighting that ending child poverty is a policy choice that requires increased political and financial commitments to key policies and programmes.

Communicating and advocating for an end to child poverty

UNICEF played an active role in supporting the G20 Brazil presidency, at both national and global levels, notably launching the report *Breaking the Cycle: Tackling Child Poverty and Inequities*¹⁴ at the G20 Social Summit. This report sheds light on the severe impact of poverty on

vulnerable groups such as girls, children with disabilities, and children from particular indigenous, racial and caste backgrounds, while also presenting effective policies to address these inequities. UNICEF was also a key partner in establishing and joining the Global Alliance against Hunger and Poverty,¹² driving accelerated efforts to eradicate hunger, malnutrition and poverty, and to reduce inequalities, including via working with Brazil to reach joint commitments between governments, development banks and international organizations for the expansion of cash transfer programmes¹³ and integrated interventions on maternal and child malnutrition.¹⁴ UNICEF's analysis on *The New Poor – Shocks and the Changing Profiles of Children Living in Poverty*¹⁵ emphasized the urgent need to swiftly evaluate and comprehend the evolving profiles of children living in poverty in a world marked by increasing fragility and shocks. This analysis, featuring examples from Bangladesh, Georgia and Uganda, aims to enhance our understanding of these shifting patterns and their policy implications.

UNICEF, in partnership with Save the Children, continued to lead the *Global Coalition to End Child Poverty*, orchestrating global commemorations for the International Day for the Eradication of Poverty. The 2024 theme, 'Ending Social and Institutional Maltreatment', underscored the critical role of institutions and society in perpetuating poverty. UNICEF spotlighted the urgent need for social protection programmes that uphold dignity, combat stigma and foster environments where all children and families can flourish. UNICEF championed high-level advocacy and forged powerful partnerships to combat child poverty across all country income settings. In Uganda, UNICEF spearheaded the launch of the National Coalition to End Child Poverty, uniting the Government of Uganda, research centres, Save the Children and other civil society organizations to raise awareness and drive action against child poverty. Meanwhile, in France, the widely publicized HOPE by

Breaking the Cycle: Tackling child poverty and inequities

In the context of the G20, UNICEF emphasized that children with disabilities are disproportionately affected by poverty and exclusion. The UNICEF report *Breaking the Cycle: Tackling Child Poverty and Inequities* advocates for inclusive policies that address the unique challenges faced by these children, ensuring their access to essential services including education, health care and social protection. The report underscores the importance of a multidimensional approach to poverty, recognizing that children with disabilities often experience multiple, overlapping deprivations that hinder their development and well-being.

"Missing school due to high costs of education... is worse for children with disabilities who face added roadblocks such as lack of learning aids like braille and sign language interpreters." Young girl at the launch of the Uganda National Coalition to End Child Poverty.

What is povertyism?

Povertyism

term

Negative attitudes and behaviours towards people living in poverty*

*Source: UN Special Rapporteur on extreme poverty and human rights



UNICEF Forum¹⁶ spotlighted the devastating effects of climate change and multiple crises on children and families living in poverty, emphasizing the crucial role of social protection in combating poverty both in France and globally.

In Malaysia, UNICEF leveraged evidence for powerful policy advocacy through the ‘Living on the Edge’ study, which highlighted the severe vulnerabilities faced by children living in urban poverty in Kuala Lumpur, especially those in households headed by women or persons with disabilities. The accompanying advocacy and communication campaign garnered extensive media and online attention. Capitalizing on this momentum, UNICEF organized the Second Regional Social Policy Forum in the state of Sarawak, convening participants from 14 countries to exchange best practices in developing inclusive, shock-responsive social protection systems.

Supporting national child poverty measurement and capacity-building

The availability of robust evidence on the situation of children and their families who are living in poverty, both monetary and multidimensional, is key to inform policies to tackle poverty. Supporting national child poverty measurement and analysis is therefore central to UNICEF’s mission in child poverty policy and programming. The number of countries measuring multidimensional child poverty – in which children are deprived of their basic rights to health, nutrition, education, water, sanitation and shelter – decreased slightly in 2024 (68 compared to 72 in 2023), and the number of countries measuring monetary child poverty remained the same as in 2023 (72). There are numerous explanations for the lack of progress in

measuring child poverty, including that the initial push and momentum created by the SDGs may have waned. There also continues to be a lag in routine poverty measurement due to gaps in the roll-out of household survey data after the COVID-19 pandemic, while in some countries there is resistance to measuring and monitoring child poverty.

In 2024, several countries measured and monitored child poverty for the first time with UNICEF support, including Iran and Uzbekistan, which analysed multidimensional child poverty, and Somalia, where monetary child poverty was included in the routine government reporting. UNICEF completed multidimensional child poverty analyses in 2024 in Fiji, Kiribati, Samoa, Tonga and Tuvalu. In Gabon, UNICEF provided technical support to the Directorate General of Statistics to conduct the first analysis of multidimensional child poverty in the country. In Uzbekistan, UNICEF championed the inclusion of multidimensional child poverty indicators in the national data collection system, leading to the Presidential Administration formally mandating relevant institutions to regularly collect these data for use in national policymaking.

Beyond the routine measurement and analysis of child poverty, UNICEF also supported household survey implementation in several countries. In Panama, with technical support from UNICEF, the Ministry of Social Development published a second measurement of the Child Multidimensional Poverty Index and committed to financing a new round of Multiple Indicator Cluster Surveys (MICS) in 2025. In Rwanda, UNICEF supported capacity-building within the National Institute of Statistics and Research, including the completion of the 7th Integrated Living Condition Survey, a critical data source for measuring the country’s progress on poverty reduction, including multidimensional child poverty estimates.

Informing policies and strategies to end child poverty

In 2024, 43 countries reported that systematic measurement, analysis and advocacy work led by UNICEF led to critical changes in policies and programmes to address child poverty, up from 38 countries in 2022. This work is critical to ensuring that analysis and advocacy translates into concrete changes in children's lives, through policy reforms that help to reduce child poverty and inequities. In several countries across the world, UNICEF brought urgent attention to the fact that children are disproportionately affected by poverty.

In Costa Rica, UNICEF highlighted that although there have been positive reductions in monetary poverty, from 21.8 per cent in 2023 to 18 per cent in 2024, child poverty decreased at a significantly slower pace (from 38 per cent in 2023 to 37 per cent in 2024) and remains stagnant, bringing urgency to the need to focus on children and their families in policies and programmes to tackle poverty. In Argentina, UNICEF brought attention to the impacts of poverty for food insecurity among children, resulting in concrete policy changes. UNICEF-supported analysis in the country showed that 52 per cent of households with children reported that they stopped buying certain food items due to income constraints, and around 30 per cent stated they had incurred debt to purchase food. These insights supported policy revisions in Argentina, including the expansion of the Alimentar Card (food card) to benefit adolescents and the adaptation of transfer amounts to keep up with inflation, ensuring that transfers were more effective in addressing children's food insecurity.

Child poverty policy analysis is a vital tool for many UNICEF country offices to protect social spending, including for social protection. In Uzbekistan, UNICEF-supported analysis demonstrated the significant impact of social benefits in reducing child poverty, which fell from 21.5 per cent in 2021 to 13.7 per cent in 2023. However, this progress also highlighted concerns around the tightening of eligibility criteria. Similarly, in Lesotho, UNICEF-supported multidimensional child poverty analysis was key in engaging with the International Monetary Fund and World Bank to prioritize child-focused investments. In Kyrgyzstan, UNICEF-supported analysis challenged the perception that social sector spending is inefficient by linking child outcomes to economic growth needs, offering a novel perspective on child poverty.

Integration of child poverty into development planning, including at decentralized levels, is key in poverty eradication, and UNICEF supports countries in these efforts. In Nigeria, for example, UNICEF advocacy and technical support led to the institutionalization of child poverty measures to inform development planning, whereby 15 states included multidimensional and monetary child poverty estimates in their state development plans. Likewise, in Malawi, UNICEF child poverty analysis was leveraged to shape national perspectives on child-inclusive programming that holistically addresses children's



A staggering 3.4 million children are living in street situations without parental care in Bangladesh. The Government of Bangladesh has made great strides in crafting policies and initiatives that benefit this population. UNICEF is working relentlessly, together with the government to protect these children from all forms of harm.

multifaceted deprivations, while ensuring the integration of child poverty more broadly into public finance management and decentralized policies (district development plans and district implementation plans).

Even in fragile and conflict-affected settings, UNICEF worked tirelessly to bring attention to the plight of children living in poverty, and the policy options to tackle child poverty. In Haiti, UNICEF integrated multidimensional child poverty measures into national planning processes, making substantial progress in addressing child poverty. Analyses from 2021 and 2024 provided critical insights into interconnected deprivations, including access to education, health care and nutrition. These insights informed targeted interventions in deprived regions and influenced national budgetary and strategic frameworks, ensuring resource allocation to areas of greatest need. By collaborating with partners, UNICEF supported the implementation of evidence-based policies aimed at breaking the cycle of poverty, particularly for children in displaced and rural communities. The objective of this holistic approach is to yield measurable impacts, improving the well-being of Haiti's most vulnerable children.

Similarly, at the regional level, UNICEF continued to provide crucial evidence on the plight of children living in poverty. UNICEF in Europe and Central Asia summarized progress¹⁷ within the European Union (EU) in addressing child poverty, revealing that one in four children (20 million) are at risk of poverty and social exclusion, and highlighted key issues for the upcoming political cycle.

Case Study 1: Advocating for Children and Their Families Living in Poverty in Uruguay

Children living in poverty were placed high on the political agenda during the 2024 general elections, in part through UNICEF-focused advocacy on the issue, highlighting that 18.6 per cent of children in Uruguay live in poverty – double the overall poverty rate in the country. There has been no sustained progress towards reducing child poverty in the last 10 years. UNICEF-generated evidence, including a 2024 study, confirmed that most Uruguayan people consider that poor families are responsible for their poverty, although 78 per cent understand that the State is to some extent responsible for reducing poverty and that current social transfers are insufficient.

The urgency to tackle child poverty and dispel myths around poverty was clear. UNICEF deployed an evidence-based advocacy strategy, with the objective to influence an increase and improve investment in social policies which tackle child poverty. UNICEF's advocacy strategy targeted presidential and legislative candidates and their teams with important advocacy messages, including that countries with similar income levels to Uruguay have significantly lower rates of child poverty. The UNICEF country office produced video explainers on child poverty that reached more than 2.3 million people through Meta, YouTube and LinkedIn. This strategy was widely reported in the national media and contributed to positioning new perspectives on child poverty as one of the country's main challenges.

As a result of these and other efforts, child poverty was high on the agenda of the political campaigns. To position child poverty as a key topic among the public, UNICEF focused its narrative on the investment that the country must make to eradicate a problem that has persisted for more than three decades. To this end, it compiled global evidence and generated local research to illustrate that, with the right policies and programmes, child poverty can be eradicated in Uruguay.

In 2024, two parliamentary initiatives aimed at reducing child poverty were approved: the Children's Fund and the Law on Guarantees for Early Childhood, Childhood and Adolescence. The first creates a non-governmental legal entity of public law, which will channel funds to implement plans and actions for the social inclusion of children and adolescents in vulnerable situations. The second proposes mechanisms for the coordination of childhood policies. UNICEF is committed to support both initiatives.



Protecting the rights of children through greater and equitable investments

In 2024, UNICEF's PF4C programming has driven significant progress in advancing child rights through the optimal use of public finance. UNICEF's efforts have focused on providing technical support and policy guidance to countries, ensuring they align their public finance strategies with the obligations outlined in Article 4 of the Convention on the Rights of the Child and General Comment 19. This work has helped to strengthen public finance systems and supported the development and execution of social sector budgets that prioritize children's rights overall, in addition to ensuring the right of every child in accessing social services, to make an increased impact on reducing child poverty.

UNICEF engaged in 144 countries. Of these, PF4C succeeded in strengthening social sector budgets for greater and better investments in children in 91 countries, up from 84 in 2023. This improvement was partly due to work on scaling up technical support, policy advice and evidence-based advocacy to improve budget allocations and engagement with partners to increase social spending. In addition, UNICEF leveraged financing from international and private sector resources for children in 85 countries, up from 71 in 2023. UNICEF also scaled up its efforts on

social sector financing, with social protection remaining the key area of focus, followed by education, health, child protection and nutrition (*see Figure 5*).

Key outcomes included the allocation of adequate resources to sectors vital for children, improved efficiency in public spending, and enhanced fiscal equity with a particular focus on marginalized children. UNICEF also strengthened the transparency and accountability of public finance systems, while encouraging greater citizen and youth participation in budgetary processes. Through these actions, UNICEF advanced a rights-based approach to financing, directly contributing to SDG 1, which aims to eliminate extreme poverty by 2030, with a focus on indicators relating to government spending on essential services and spending benefiting the poorest.

PF4C has been instrumental in addressing child poverty through influencing the strategic leveraging, allocation and use of domestic public financial resources. These efforts have resulted in more equitable and sustainable outcomes for children, particularly through strengthened social sector budgets that reduce both monetary and multidimensional poverty, ensuring that children have equitable access

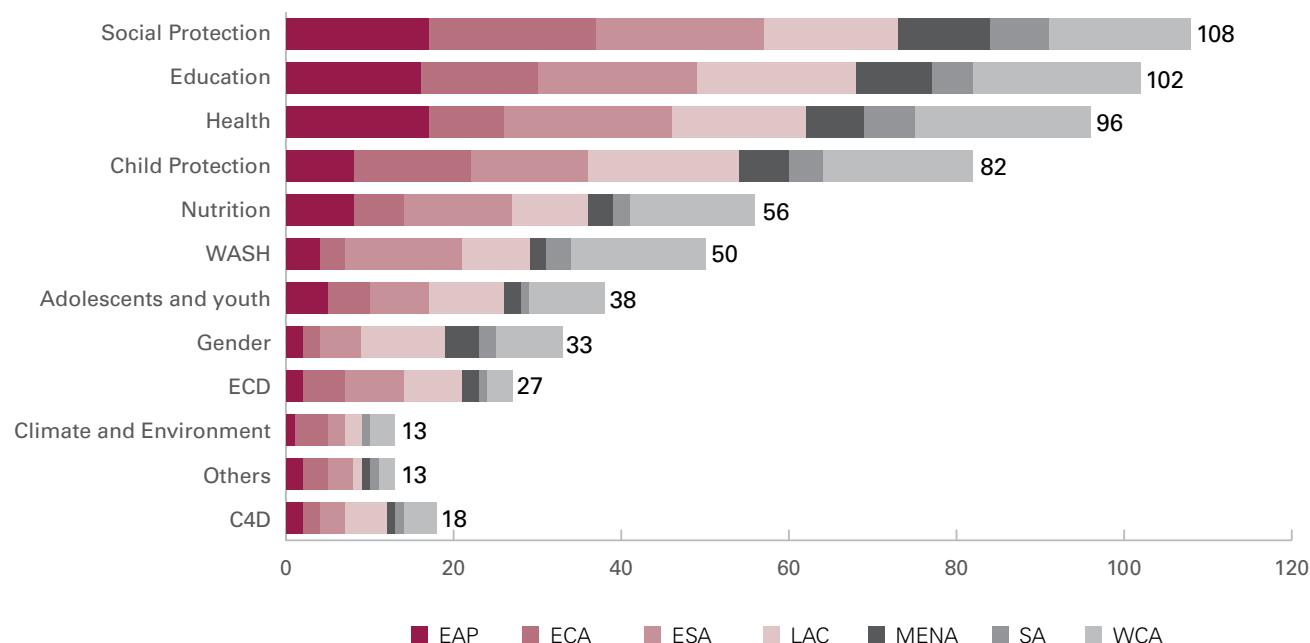


On 8 November 2023, children play in a child-friendly space established with UNICEF support in Nalgad Municipality in Jajarkot District in the wake of the 6.4 magnitude earthquake that struck Nepal on 3 November 2023.

These child-friendly spaces provide children with a safe and protective space to play and participate in learning and recreational activities under adult supervision. It also provides an opportunity for children to be away from the tension and travails their families faced in the aftermath of the earthquake.

UNICEF has been on the ground since day one, working around the clock with the Government and partners to assess and respond to the impact of the earthquake on communities in Jajarkot and Rukum West Districts.

FIGURE 5. UNICEF's PF4C work, by sector



C4D, Communication for Development; ECD, Early childhood development; WASH, Water, sanitation and hygiene.

to well-financed services. Building on these efforts, UNICEF has further strengthened its partnerships by collaborating with the Inter-Agency Taskforce on Financing for Development, particularly through the 4th Financing for Development (FFD4) Conference processes. This engagement positions UNICEF to advocate more effectively for children's rights in global forums, such as the upcoming FFD4 in Seville, Spain.

UNICEF engagement in the 2nd Preparatory Committee of FFD4 focused on social sector financing, financing in fragile and humanitarian settings,¹⁸ and innovative, sustainable financing solutions to accelerate the SDGs. Other areas of support included policy discussions around the Integrated National Financing Framework (INFF) Facility, local finance and social protection financing. These collaborations align directly with UNICEF's ongoing commitment to elevate the voice of children in global financing discussions, reinforcing the importance of integrated, country-driven approaches to achieving the SDGs. By working alongside partners like OECD, UNDESA, UNDP and the Governments of Italy, Spain and Sweden, UNICEF is advancing an integrated approach to financing for sustainable development, exemplified in the joint publication with the INFF facility, Making Finance Work for People and Planet.¹⁹ Through these strategic partnerships, UNICEF continues to drive a comprehensive, child-centred financing agenda on financing for development at the global stage.

Promoting adequate investment for children's rights

UNICEF engaged with governments at central and decentralized levels to influence sufficient resource allocations to ensure the right of every child to social services. Anchoring its work on evidence-based and context-driven solutions, this work helped to protect, expand and transform public social spending for children, resulting in fiscal sustainability and the stability of public budgets. In contexts where public resources were insufficient to finance social services for children, UNICEF focused on leveraging international resources, including complementary/blended private sector finance. In Montenegro, the education system faces significant challenges, including inadequate infrastructure, limited teacher training and poor digital access. Over 40 per cent of 15-year-olds struggle with reading comprehension, and, in 2021, public spending on education was only 8.9 per cent of the state budget, far below the global benchmark. UNICEF led an Education Sector Analysis in 2022 and produced an Education Budget Brief in 2023, highlighting severe underfunding. This advocacy led to government action, securing over €27 million for 2024–2026 to enhance teacher training, school infrastructure and digitalization, with UNICEF and EU support driving long-term education reform.

Making public spending for children more efficient and effective

In 2024, UNICEF prioritized enhancing the efficiency and effectiveness of public budgets to ensure equitable and sustainable financing for social sectors. This included supporting governments in generating savings within public budgets, enabling the redirection of resources to priority social spending that directly impacts child rights and long-term human capital development. For instance, in Oman, UNICEF successfully promoted a balanced approach, safeguarding essential social budgets while improving efficiency. Through Fiscal Space Analysis, UNICEF identified alternative funding sources, including Islamic finance and Corporate Social Responsibility, and aligned social financing with Oman's Medium-Term Fiscal Plan. High-level costing analyses of health and education revealed funding gaps and efficiency opportunities, leading to their integration into Oman's Medium-Term Budget and Expenditure Framework. These efforts led to concrete actions, including the formation of internal committees within the Ministry of Health to implement fiscal efficiency measures. UNICEF's work continues to ensure sustainable financing for child-focused development, strengthening fiscal stability in the process.

Making public social spending more equitable

In 2024, UNICEF prioritized ensuring equitable distribution of public resources to guarantee that all children, especially marginalized groups, have access to essential social services. By focusing on fiscal equity, UNICEF aimed to direct resources where they are needed most, addressing poverty and reducing inequality. In Barbados and the Eastern Caribbean, UNICEF's work made public social spending more equitable, particularly for marginalized children. In Antigua and Barbuda, the British Virgin Islands, Dominica, and Trinidad and Tobago, UNICEF conducted budget analysis and fiscal space assessments. These efforts highlighted the integration of climate-sensitive social protection, aligning adaptation policies with social spending to enhance resilience and improve outcomes for vulnerable children.

UNICEF also promotes disability inclusive financing to ensure a right-based approach. In Armenia, UNICEF provided technical assistance to the Ministry of Labor and Social Affairs and generated key evidence, including a study on the costs of disability inclusion, which informed Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities-compliant budgeting analysis and guided the design of new programmes for children with disabilities. UNICEF contributed to the government's medium-term expenditure framework and annual budget planning processes, resulting in increased national budget commitments for disability-inclusive services. Globally, UNICEF has conducted the first international comparative study of national budgets from

a disability perspective across 14 low- and middle-income countries and has led the drafting of the financing chapter of the Global Disability Inclusion Report²⁰.

Promoting transparency, accountability and participation

UNICEF also focused on enhancing transparency in social sector budgets and fostering citizen participation in budgetary processes, which are crucial for improving public oversight and ensuring more effective allocation and spending of public funds for children's rights. In Egypt, UNICEF built on its successful collaboration in fiscal transparency by facilitating a series of policy discussions around the 2023 Open Budget Survey (OBS) results. These discussions led to the presentation of actionable recommendations to the Vice Minister of Finance and key Ministry of Finance units. As a result of UNICEF's ongoing support in OBS analysis and capacity development, Egypt achieved significant improvements in its 2023 OBS scores. Transparency increased by 6 basis points, making Egypt the second-highest in the Middle East and North Africa region, surpassing the global average, while public participation rose by 16 basis points, positioning Egypt first in the region and eighth globally.



Hosnia Abdul, a 20-year-old, a pregnant and lactating mother of a one-year-old son is a beneficiary of UNICEF's cash plus programme - Mother and Child Cash Transfer programme. Through the programme she received cash grants and used part of the money to buy fruits, vegetables, meat and eggs.

Case study 2: Transforming the public financial management architecture in Tanzania

Persistent gaps in budget implementation in Zanzibar have hindered the delivery of essential services, affecting children and vulnerable populations. Service delivery was further hindered by lack of adequate and consistent data and inconsistent funding for critical sectors such as health, education and gender. Addressing these inefficiencies required institutional reforms to better align planning with budget implementation and results. UNICEF collaborated with the President's Office Finance and Planning (POFP) to establish a dedicated budget monitoring and accountability unit to oversee budget implementation and improve service delivery.

In close collaboration with the POFP and with emphasis on local ownership, UNICEF provided technical support to strengthen budget monitoring and accountability functions. UNICEF provided technical support building capacity for Ministries and facilitated partnerships with institutions including the International Monetary Fund through the Africa Regional Technical Assistance Centers. The collaboration improved budget quality and credibility and social sector funding, resulting in a tripling of the school feeding budget, securing dedicated health-care facility accounts, and allocating US\$22 million for gender and equity initiatives across six priority sectors.

By 2023, the budget monitoring and accountability unit became fully institutionalized within POFP. This unit successfully delivered Zanzibar's first High-Level Budget Monitoring Symposium. This initiative demonstrates how strategic technical assistance and local ownership can drive lasting improvements in public financial management.



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Public finance for children in fragile and humanitarian contexts

In 2024, UNICEF focused on overcoming the challenges that conflict and fragility pose to governments' ability to expand social spending through taxation and borrowing, limiting the fiscal space for financing essential social services. In these contexts, international, particularly humanitarian, funding is critical to ensuring children's rights. UNICEF's efforts were directed towards strengthening resilient, risk-informed public finance management systems to support shock-responsive social spending. In Guinea-Bissau, amidst economic fragility, UNICEF advanced PF4C initiatives through high-level advocacy, enabling the country's participation in the 9th edition of the OBS for the first time in 2023. The country's participation was followed by the launch of its OBS results in 2024, assessing transparency in public finance management, budget information accessibility and public participation. Ranking 117 out of 125 countries, Guinea-Bissau committed to publishing key budget documents in 2025 and enhancing public participation in the budgeting process, marking a significant step toward more transparent and accountable fiscal management.

Local governance for poverty reduction

In 2024, UNICEF's subnational and local governance programming successfully contributed to improved outcomes for children by addressing local issues across diverse contexts, including rural, urban and fragile settings. Local governments, in collaboration with key stakeholders, played a critical role in ensuring equitable access to services for marginalized communities. UNICEF's support led to a significant increase in the number of local governments adopting child-responsive development plans and budgets, reaching 4,841 in 2024, up from 4,183 in 2023. To achieve this, UNICEF provided technical assistance to 117 countries and 22 UNICEF National Committees, enabling 74 countries (a 16 per cent increase from 2023) to engage systematically with subnational and local governments to address capacity gaps in local governance. This contributed to the design of more child-responsive plans and budgets, exceeding the 2024 global target by 22 countries. This assistance focused primarily on participation, fiscal decentralization, localization, the Child Friendly Cities Initiative (CFCI) and risk-informed programming in fragile contexts.

UNICEF supported inclusive, participatory, transparent and accountable decision-making processes at subnational and local levels by enhancing the voice and agency of all children, adolescents, caregivers and communities to effectively address local issues, including issues related to reducing exclusion, inequality and poverty. UNICEF teams across 117 country offices made notable progress in

supporting the establishment and functioning of inclusive and representative participatory mechanisms at the local level for children and adolescents. UNICEF's engagement at the local level contributed to a positive trend in both the establishment of participatory mechanisms and the resulting progress, illustrating the country teams' ongoing efforts in fostering inclusive governance at the local level, with the aim of strengthening capacities and systems for children's participation in the development of child-responsive policies and plans at local level.

In Kosovo, UNICEF strengthened local engagement by supporting the establishment of Child Rights Teams in four municipalities to bridge the gap between policy and implementation. Child Rights Teams, established in line with the Law on Child Protection, are chaired by Mayors and include key municipal directors, civil society representatives and children. These teams are responsible for monitoring and reporting on child rights. UNICEF facilitated their work by developing Children's Work Plans, endorsed by the Municipal Assembly, to prioritize child rights issues and promote evidence-based planning. Additionally, UNICEF supported quality service delivery in early childhood development, expanded early education and engaged youth through Innovation Hubs in selected municipalities. Applying the disability lens, in Bosnia and Herzegovina, Eritrea, Jamaica, Myanmar and Rwanda, UNICEF engaged systematically with partners and subnational governments to develop child-responsive local policies, programmes and plans focused on children with disabilities. These efforts have led to improved outcomes and prioritization for children with disabilities in at least one local governance area in each country.

In 2024, UNICEF's engagement with public financial management processes at the local level aims to enhance financing for essential services and improve the well-being of children living in multidimensional poverty, both in developing and high-income countries. UNICEF support targeted initiatives to address fiscal imbalances in local financing that hinder efforts to reduce child poverty. UNICEF partnered with local governments, ministries of finance and development partners to strengthen local financing and budgeting processes, focusing on improving child and adolescent outcomes. UNICEF teams across countries focused on strengthening intergovernmental frameworks and coordination, including improving equity, targeting and timeliness of intergovernmental fiscal transfers and strengthening systems and processes for coordinating bottom-up and top-down planning and budgeting. UNICEF supported 117 country offices in developing child-responsive local budgets, with 37 countries engaging in regular interventions to promote fiscal decentralization, up from 32 in 2023. This positive trend indicates a growing commitment to child-responsive budgeting, enhancing national and local government capacities to mobilize, allocate and monitor resources effectively in the social sectors, through fiscal decentralization.

In Lao People's Democratic Republic, in partnership with UNDP, UNICEF strengthened national and subnational capacities for results-based planning and budgeting to more effectively address the challenges faced by children living in multidimensional poverty. In Madagascar, building on findings from the MICS, UNICEF carried out awareness-raising activities on issues related to children living in multidimensional poverty. These efforts included advocacy for integrating children's rights into local planning documents, capacity-building in budget analysis (particularly municipal budgets and administrative accounts), and support for budgeting health and education programmes at the municipal level.

In Mozambique, within the framework of its systematic advocacy to improve central and local planning and budgeting, UNICEF, together with the Permanent Secretary of the Ministry of Finance, organized a joint engagement on service delivery in times of fiscal crisis with representatives of all levels of government for the International Monetary Fund, World Bank, the EU and UNDP. The discussions with the provincial and district authorities, coupled with visits to schools and health posts, unveiled the impact of the fiscal crisis on front-line workers and teachers, with facilities deprived of electricity and water for lack of budget for recurrent expenditures. This reality check prompted the preparation of a joint public financial management reform plan to ensure districts and facilities receive minimum levels of financing to guarantee basic service delivery levels, while the state restores its fiscal sustainability. As part of this effort, UNICEF and the World Bank supported the development of a Medium-term Budgeting Framework to shift from incremental budgeting towards a more strategic use of resources. This will be complemented by costing service delivery and developing a balanced system of intergovernmental fiscal transfers, from central to provincial and district levels. By optimizing intergovernmental fiscal coordination, Mozambique, like other UNICEF countries, aimed to ensure that all functional mandates and responsibilities assigned to local governments, especially for the delivery of social services, are adequately financed. UNICEF will renew its focus on directing fiscal transfers from national to local levels, towards initiatives that support child-centred outcomes, enhance local financing for social services delivery and promote a cohesive government approach to child right.

Subnational and local governments and their associations have been actively supporting the localization of the 2030 Agenda, bringing the SDGs closer to the people they serve and using the framework as a tool for planning and policy implementation. In 2024, the United Nations' Local 2030 Coalition, and its SDG Fund Localization Window, focused on on-the-ground delivery of the SDGs as they provided funding to 13 UNICEF offices at country level^b for key programming interventions. In these 13 countries,

SDG localization remained the most effective platform for fostering collaboration among all relevant actors, mobilizing knowledge, resources and skills to achieve the 2030 Agenda. UNICEF country offices' efforts in localizing the SDGs have concentrated on strengthening data and evidence, improving local governance planning and budgeting, and co-designing innovative service delivery models, financing tools and accountability mechanisms with both public and private partners. This approach to local governance programming has advanced SDG localization to a notable extent and improved results for children at the local level, as seen in countries including Ghana, Serbia and Honduras.

In 22 high-income countries, UNICEF National Committees engaged in local governance programming through the CFCI, further enhancing implementation of child rights and achieving tangible results for children at the local level, with a focus on marginalized and excluded children. In these high-income countries, UNICEF worked with municipalities in implementing local programming. The participating municipalities committed to realize child rights at local level, through the establishment of an action plan for children with a dedicated budget and institutionalized mechanisms for child and adolescent participation. The initiative has registered notable sustainable positive changes in the life of children in selected municipalities, with potential for scalability in other cities and municipalities. In these high-income countries, local governance programming through CFCI provided a platform for partnerships and engagement, facilitating the mobilization of governments and various stakeholders to develop, fund and implement an action plan to address identified child rights deprivations and disparities. Child and youth participation, as well as social inclusion, were reported as crucial in determining priority actions in these countries.

In fragile contexts, UNICEF looked to local governments as the authority mandated to coordinate stakeholders at the level of subnational jurisdiction, and supported local authorities to perform this function, while working with and through other local actors to enhance preparedness. To that effect, initial engagement and advocacy with national government to address capacity of local governance systems based on CFCI methodologies and approaches have started in several countries in fragile contexts. In these contexts, UNICEF developed Risk-Informed Programming Guidance²¹ and the Technical Note on Strengthening Resilience through Risk-informed Decentralization and Local Governance²² to provide information, tools and programming approaches for ensuring that subnational and local governance programming is risk-sensitive and considers specific roles of all stakeholders for preparedness and disaster risk reduction.

^b Countries included Barbados, Cameroon, Egypt, Equatorial Guinea, Gambia, Ghana, Georgia, Honduras, Kenya, Liberia, Serbia, State of Palestine and Tajikistan.

Child-responsive urban policies and standards

In 2024, 18 countries had child-responsive urban policies and spatial planning standards, up from 15 in 2023. Core pillars of work focused on ensuring that urban policies are based on standards and norms for children and on evidence pertaining to children, and reflect children's views and needs. In Malaysia, UNICEF's advocacy with the Ministry of Finance in 2024 led to a budget allocation of RM5 million (US\$1.12 million) towards a Cash-Plus pilot for Kuala Lumpur for families in low-income housing to tackle poverty and malnutrition, with options for national scale up. At the subnational level, UNICEF supported

2,350 city governments in 29 countries to implement child development plans. In Zimbabwe, the Government announced a Call to Action, to improve spatial planning and address structural challenges including informal settlements. In China, UNICEF worked with several Government agencies to develop technical standards for children's play and recreation systems, as well as child-friendly spaces and parks. In India, UNICEF provided technical support to the Urban Policy Commission set up by the state of Kerala to bring children centre stage in the new urban policy of the state. These results reflect UNICEF's continued efforts to strengthen policies and programmes to address structural barriers to child well-being in urban settings, slums and informal settlements.

Access to inclusive and integrated social protection systems in all contexts

In 2024, UNICEF continued its efforts in a challenging environment to close the coverage gap and support the development and strengthening of integrated, inclusive and shock-responsive social protection systems in all country contexts. These efforts aimed at ensuring the unique needs and vulnerabilities of children are effectively addressed. As a result, 88 countries reported having moderately strong or strong systems, reflecting a 10 per cent increase from the previous year.

Reaching every child: Expanding inclusive social protection coverage

In 2024, UNICEF continued its advocacy and technical assistance to support the maintenance and expansion of social protection coverage, ensuring inclusive access to family or child benefits, a fundamental pillar of social protection systems. UNICEF supports the scaling up of child benefits to reduce child poverty and yield wider positive social and economic impacts. Over 170 million children across 102 million households were reached with cash transfers supported by UNICEF, in both development and humanitarian contexts. This included a nearly 80 per cent increase in the number of children with disabilities from 2023 and more than double the number of children on the move compared to 2023. Child benefits were acknowledged as a proven solution for children.²³ Jointly with the International Labour Organization (ILO) and Save the Children, UNICEF launched the Child Benefit Tracker,²⁴ an online platform to monitor children's access to social protection and identify coverage gaps.

In 2024, UNICEF supported several countries to achieve significant advancements in expanding child benefits through various pathways. In Morocco, UNICEF supported a groundbreaking milestone by covering 80 per cent of its child population – approximately 8.8 million children – through its child benefit programme. In Thailand, ongoing advocacy efforts supported by UNICEF resulted in a proposal to the Cabinet to make the Child Support Grant universal by removing restrictive poverty thresholds. This change would allow all children under 6 years of age and pregnant women from their second trimester to be eligible. Evidence-driven analysis revealed persistent exclusion errors in the current scheme, strengthening the case for reform. UNICEF offices also supported national efforts to ensure better adequacy of benefits, with Malawi, for instance, institutionalizing annual reviews of transfer values to align benefits with inflation trends.

The commitment to upholding the rights of all children to leave no child behind has taken various forms through gender-responsive social protection. For example, in Bangladesh, with the support of the Power4Girls Gender Thematic Fund, in 2024 UNICEF supported the expansion of coverage to adolescent girls through the Mother and Child Benefit Programme for pregnant and lactating mothers from poor and vulnerable families. The programme provides monthly cash transfers and support in receiving social services to reduce maternal mortality and improve the nutritional status of children.

UNICEF also expanded its support to disability-inclusive cash transfer programmes in multiple countries, addressing both poverty and the additional costs of disability. In Rwanda, a pilot child disability grant supported 842

households, while in Senegal, a digital top-up reached 22,038 children, including children with disabilities. In Tunisia, the AMEN Social programme provided a monthly top-up to the child benefits to over 7,350 children with disabilities, and in Sao Tome and Principe, the Parental Education Programme expanded to reach 4,070 families, including those with children with disabilities. In Pakistan, UNICEF provided technical support to the government to reach 24,449 children with disability, among others, with cash transfers and complementary services such as nutrition counselling. To further improve policy effectiveness, UNICEF conducted cost analyses in Armenia, Namibia, Nepal, Malaysia and Uzbekistan, helping governments to understand the additional costs faced by families of children with disabilities and make informed decisions about resource allocation for inclusive social protection.

Accelerated by global momentum to strengthen access to social protection for children on the move and efforts to transition displaced persons from humanitarian programmes into national social protection systems, UNICEF has worked to bridge emergency cash transfers to long-term resilience strengthening, inclusion and empowerment of children on the move and their families through access to social protection. In 2024, UNICEF reached 900,000 children on the move with cash transfers as part of humanitarian and development programming. UNICEF collaborates with governments to address de jure and de facto barriers for children on the move by integrating displacement considerations into the key building blocks of social protection institutionalization within government. The increasing number of UNICEF offices reporting on the state of inclusion of migrant and displaced populations in national social protection systems highlights both the relevance and the progress in this area.

Social protection enabling environment: Legislation, policy and financing

In 2024, UNICEF supported countries worldwide to reinforce the essential foundations of robust inclusive and integrated systems at the policy, programme and administrative levels. UNICEF continued its support at the legal and policy level, defending rights-based, child-sensitive social protection policy frameworks and working towards securing sustainable financing. A new National Strategy on Social Protection 2024–2030, developed with UNICEF support, was adopted by the Government of Albania. Adopting a life cycle ethos, this Strategy integrates a shock-responsive approach, mainstreams gender and underscores its commitment to the Child Guarantee Action Plan. The strategy reflected the voices of youth through the UNICEF-coordinated United Nations Youth Task Force. In Benin, UNICEF contributed to the development and adoption of a

Holistic Social Protection Policy, which includes a dedicated budgeted action plan and integrates essential dimensions such as gender and people with disabilities, as well as crisis situations and climate change. The policy helps to guarantee equal rights for all children in Benin and their access to essential social services. In Kosovo, a new Law on Evaluation, Status Recognition, Benefits and Services for Persons with Disabilities was approved. In Cambodia, UNICEF supported the development of the National Disability Strategic Plan 2024–2028, which includes a focus on social protection.

As co-chair of the USP2030 Financing working Group, UNICEF coordinated global advocacy on strengthening social protection financing systems in the framework of the International Conference on Financing for Development, contributing to concrete commitments made on social protection financing in the draft outcome document. At the country level, achievements included the support provided by UNICEF in partnership with the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations in the Caribbean to integrate social protection into Nationally Determined Contributions, a key tool that informs the allocation of climate finance and can contribute to closing the social protection financing gaps. In Azerbaijan, UNICEF successfully partnered with United Nations Environment Programme to access the Green Climate Fund for strengthening climate information and the Multi-Hazard Early Warning System for resilience building in the country. Among other interventions, this project includes developing a roadmap for Forecast-based Financing and building capacities of the Ministry of Labour and Social Protection to institutionalize Multi-Hazard Early Warning System-linked Forecast-based Financing for enhancing the shock responsiveness of the social protection system. UNICEF has also worked to ensure adequate financing of social protection to meet the needs of children with disabilities. In Mongolia, government investments in child protection and social welfare increased, including budget allocations to a Development Centre for Children with Disabilities and enhanced allowances for children with severe disabilities. In Angola, UNICEF-supported advocacy led to increased government funding for disability inclusion.

UNICEF continued its role as a leading member of the United Nations' Global Accelerator (GA) on Jobs and Social Protection for Just Transitions, being involved in the 18 Pathfinder countries that made a high-level commitment to creating decent jobs, expanding social protection and promoting pathways for just transitions. UNICEF has been working alongside other United Nations agencies to support governments in catalysing national-level financial commitments to critical areas that can accelerate progress and address gaps in expanding social protection coverage for all, including children. UNICEF is working actively in 10 of these countries,^c providing support on issues such as the expansion of child benefits, the enhancement of social protection delivery, disability-inclusive and

^c Albania, Cambodia, Colombia, Indonesia, Namibia, Nepal, Paraguay, Philippines, Senegal, Uzbekistan

gender-responsive social protection, social protection strengthening and its linkages with skills and active labour market policies, and the strengthening of care and support systems. Through the Multi-stakeholder Engagement to implement the GA and the World Bank Social Protection

Compass (M-GA), UNICEF is working with the World Bank in six countries^d to advance efficiency and collaboration to create decent, productive employment and expand social protection for all.

Towards more inclusive social protection systems

Improving gender responsiveness

In 2024, 136 UNICEF country offices reported having integrated gender-specific objectives in their support to national and subnational social protection systems, compared to 129 UNICEF country offices in 2023. Of these, 70 UNICEF country offices indicated that the UNICEF-supported social protection programmes tackled gender-based violence, 70 countries had social protection programmes that aimed to increase girls' access to education, 60 countries sought to improve access to maternity benefits and sexual and reproductive health services, and 55 targeted results to increase women and girls' decision-making through social protection programmes, demonstrating improvements in all areas of work from 2023. Notably, UNICEF also witnessed a 23 per cent increase in countries achieving gender-responsive or transformative social protection results, increasing from 64 in 2023 to 79 countries in 2024.

In addition, 2024 marked the launch of the findings and dissemination of a six-year research partnership with the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) of the Government of the UK on Gender-Responsive and Age-Sensitive Social Protection, covering a total of nine countries, 11 studies and more than 60 publications on how and why to invest in more gender-responsive social protection. Around the world, UNICEF also advanced a commitment to participatory policymaking and social accountability for women and girls by publishing a mini documentary and report spanning 30 countries, capturing their lived experiences and urgent demands through the *We Deserve Better* initiative, in partnership with the William and Flora Hewlett Foundation and FCDO.

Enhancing the offer for children with disabilities

In 2024, UNICEF made significant strides in strengthening inclusive social protection systems for children with disabilities, with a strong focus on improving data collection and disability identification mechanisms. In Gabon, a national census of persons with disabilities allowed integration of 4,345 children with disabilities into the national social protection system. In Bosnia and Herzegovina, UNICEF supported the reform of disability identification and over 600 children were newly included. UNICEF has also been supporting app-based, digitized disability assessments, including the screening of 300,000 individuals in Nepal.

At delivery level, UNICEF supported the expansion of social protection support for children with disabilities by enhancing service delivery across multiple countries. In Kosovo, significant reforms in child and social protection, supported by UNICEF, included the expansion of services for children with disabilities. Service delivery has expanded through initiatives like Disability-Inclusive Technical and Vocational Education and Training under the Decent Employment for Youth programme in Cambodia, which empowers youth with disabilities to access inclusive employment opportunities.

Evidence-based advocacy has also played a key role. In Armenia, a UNICEF-commissioned study on the extra costs faced by families with children with disabilities, combined with an analysis of disability spending in line with the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities, helped to inform the design of new programmes and

^d The “Multi-stakeholder engagement for the Implementation of the [Global Accelerator \(GA\) for Jobs and Social Protection](#) and the World Bank’s Jobs and Social Protection Compass” – known as [M-GA](#) is an integrated technical and financing mechanism that aims to foster collaboration between UN organizations and the World Bank. The M-GA support increased collaboration and collective action, under national leadership, to extend social protection and enable job creation. UNICEF has been working with the World Bank in 2024 under the M-GA in Cambodia, Colombia, Indonesia, Nepal, Philippines, Uzbekistan

service packages. UNICEF's technical assistance also contributed to amendments in regulations governing personal assistant services and day-care centres, ensuring children with disabilities receive individualized support that enables greater participation in daily life, education and community activities. At the global level, UNICEF co-launched a joint guidance on Disability Inclusive Social Protection Systems developed with ILO, World Bank, World Food Programme (WFP), UK FCDO, Government of Australia Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ), the International Disability Alliance and others.

Inclusion of children on the move

The PROSPECTS Partnership^e has served as an important framework to accelerate the inclusion of forcibly displaced persons in national social protection systems, and has fostered collaboration between UNICEF, United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) and the ILO to ensure complementary and coordinated technical support to host governments. In Kenya, for example, the three agencies worked with the Government to reform the national social protection strategy to expand coverage to refugees and migrants. In addition, UNICEF supported Government counterparts in major refugee-hosting counties, Turkana and Garissa, to review county budget processes and increase domestic budgets for child-critical services.

Integrated cash plus models have been central to enhancing the impact of cash transfers for displaced families by supporting their access to complementary services, such as child protection support or improved educational outcomes tailored to their specific needs. In Jordan, UNICEF is working with the Government to institutionalize a cash-plus approach to further sustain the positive impact for both displaced and host communities achieved through the Makani centres and cash transfer programme. UNICEF further supports governments to integrate displaced populations into national social registries and social protection information systems, and foster integration with other relevant databases to improve policy planning and service delivery. In Egypt, UNICEF supported Government counterparts to work with the national statistics agency to integrate refugees and migrants into the master sample frame for national surveys, addressing long-standing data gaps.

Strengthening systems integration and linkages to social services

In 2024, UNICEF strengthened national capacities to implement integrated approaches to social protection systems to ensure children and their families have effective and integrated access to services that improve their well-being. UNICEF continued to strengthen the capacity of key social protection actors at global, regional, national and local levels to enhance programmatic and administrative capabilities. UNICEF delivered two online modules on financing disability-inclusive social protection, attended by 89 participants from 42 countries. The participants were alumni of the Inclusive Social Protection course, delivered in partnership with Bonn-Rhein-Sieg University. Similarly, at country level the empowerment of the social workforce played a pivotal role in bridging gaps in access and service delivery. In Libya, UNICEF played a pivotal role in strengthening the country's social protection institutions through capacity-building efforts under the TRANSFORM^f programme, which included topics such as policy design, targeting and cash transfer systems.

A critical backbone of effective and integrated social protection delivery is the capacity of social welfare and front-line workers. In Albania, the licensing of 597 new social workers doubled capacity, enhancing the country's ability to provide direct care, referrals and follow-up through harmonized case management tools. UNICEF programming approaches on inclusion of children on the move in social protection programmes include efforts to build the capacity of the social service workforce to better respond to the needs of children on the move. UNICEF-targeted training to over 3,900 social workers and child protection officers in Moldova improved case management delivery for Ukrainian refugee children in the country.

UNICEF continued to support countries to link social protection to other sectors to more effectively and efficiently address the multiple vulnerabilities faced by children and their families, including those of women and girls. UNICEF provided support in Ethiopia in implementing cash-plus linkages, providing social protection beneficiaries with access to services in nutrition, education and health care to tackle multidimensional vulnerabilities. In Cambodia, UNICEF supported the roll-out of the long-term Social Assistance Family Package, which is designed to provide support and facilitate access to services in an integrated manner, including during crises. By the end

^e The Dutch MFA-funded PROSPECTS Partnership brings together UNICEF, UNHCR, the ILO, World Bank and International Finance Corporation to improve access to rights and basic services and enhance access to socioeconomic opportunities for displaced and host communities in eight countries: Egypt, Ethiopia, Iraq, Jordan, Kenya, Lebanon, Sudan and Uganda. It focuses on four pillars: education and learning; economic inclusion; protection, including social protection; and critical infrastructure.

^f TRANSFORM | Building Social Protection Floors in Africa

of 2024, 639,000 households were registered, with a 95 per cent registration rate. In Sierra Leone, through the Global Programme to End Child Marriage, UNICEF social policy and child protection teams worked together through the Safe Adolescence for Everyone Social Safety Net programme to eradicate child marriage in a country where 30 per cent of girls and 7 per cent of boys are married before the age of 18 years. The novel approach leverages the national social protection system to provide cash support, access to social services and social workers, adolescent empowerment on life skills and sexual and reproductive health services for girls and boys, and household and community sensitization on the risks of child marriage and early pregnancy.

At the administrative level, UNICEF continued to support the digitalization of social protection information management systems and their interoperability, contributing to making social protection systems more transparent, efficient and accountable, and supporting evidence-based implementation and a systems approach to social protection. For example, in Guatemala, UNICEF supported the utilization of the national Social Household Registry to identify 60,848 households for inclusion in social cash transfer programmes. This systematic approach supported the integration of beneficiaries into broader adaptive social protection measures, ensuring a coordinated and targeted response during crises. UNICEF also made significant strides in strengthening inclusion



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Su Darli Aung, a 2-year-old girl living with disability, is pictured with her mother and other family members. Su Darli Aung's family has been receiving cash grant support provided by UNICEF's Social Policy and Child Rights Monitoring (SPCRM) program through local partner organizations. This support followed a disability screening event conducted last year by the UNICEF team to register children living with disabilities in southern Shan State.

through data and information systems mechanisms, particularly of children and families with disabilities. In Cambodia, 50,000 more persons with disabilities were registered in a Disability Management Information System. In the Maldives, a disability registry with over 13,000 beneficiaries was also developed with UNICEF support to ensure coverage by social protection schemes. In Sierra Leone and Niger, UNICEF supported the first disability assessment pilots to prepare for the set-up of the national Disability Management Information system. At the global level, under the Disability Convergence Initiative, UNICEF led the development of interoperability standards to link disability registries with social protection management information systems, to strengthen coordination and data use across sectors.

Family-friendly policies and care and support systems

Unpaid care continues to be one of the most significant barriers to gender equality and social inclusion around the world. According to ILO global estimates, 708 million women are being prevented from entering the labour workforce due to unpaid care responsibilities. Among adolescents, 94 per cent of girls spend an average of 5 hours and 15 minutes per day on unpaid care, leading to harmful long-term consequences such as loss of education and economic opportunities.

In response to this growing care crisis, UNICEF has strengthened its commitment to supporting the development of multi-sectoral care and support systems that are both gender-responsive and disability-inclusive. This work is led by the Global Social Policy Technical Team on Care and Family-Friendly Policies, in collaboration with other sectoral teams. In 2024, UNICEF expanded its support to 87 countries, representing more than half of all programme countries and territories across nearly every region of the world. Progress has been notable. UNICEF offices in 50 countries reported active efforts to link care and support services with national social protection programmes and systems. In 40 countries, UNICEF supported the initiation of national consultations to update or introduce care and support policies and in 21 countries UNICEF supported access of community disability support services. In 32 countries, UNICEF began national reviews on the status of family-friendly policies. These efforts reflect a growing commitment by governments to address the care needs of families.

Regional momentum has also been building. Europe and Central Asia, South Asia, and East Asia and Pacific have embarked upon regional care and support strategies to solidify their regional commitment. More than 65 per cent of countries where UNICEF works in the Middle East and North Africa region have prioritized care and support policies to benefit women, children and families.

At national level, several countries have made important strides. In Brazil, UNICEF contributed to the Working Group responsible for developing the National Care Policy, including on financing of the care policy. China continues to make strides with the incorporation of maternity health insurance into national health insurance for formal sector employees. In Moldova, UNICEF facilitated a national dialogue on the EU Child Guarantee, which led to the development of a roadmap for strengthening childcare, endorsed by the Ministries of Labour, Education and Health. As part of Moldova's RESTART social assistance reform, UNICEF has also provided technical support to expand care services, particularly for children with disabilities.

Building on its broader efforts to identify children with disabilities and connect them with cash transfer programmes, UNICEF is supporting the development of inclusive, community-based care systems. In Laos, a disability cash transfer pilot is being implemented, combining financial assistance with counselling and access to assistive technology.

With support from the United Nations Global Disability Fund, UNICEF and Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights have developed a country assessment tool for care and support systems in low- and middle-income countries. UNICEF is also part of a joint United Nations programme on unpaid care, gender and disability in Kenya, Colombia and Panama. In partnership with the UK FCDO, UNICEF developed an evidence compendium on promising practices for gender-responsive and disability-inclusive care systems in low- and middle-income countries. UNICEF also contributed to two United Nations system-wide policy papers on care and support systems, reinforcing its role in advancing global dialogue and action.

Case Study 3: Reaching the unreached – expanding social protection for all children in Kenya

UNICEF has supported the Government of Kenya (GoK) over the past few decades while it has made great strides in developing a publicly financed National Safety Net Programme (NSNP). The NSNP targets orphans and vulnerable children, persons with severe disabilities and older people in all 47 counties, plus chronically poor households in arid and semi-arid areas. The establishment of a publicly financed NSNP is a huge achievement to support approximately one third of children under the food poverty line and the nearly one fifth who are chronically malnourished (as of 2022). Refugee children are particularly vulnerable, with poverty rates as high as 39 per cent in Kenya's Kalobeyei refugee settlement.

To address this, UNICEF has worked with GoK to expand the NSNP by nearly 70 per cent, from 1 million households in 2023 to 1.7 million in 2024 with a Presidential commitment to reach 2.5 million households. In addition, UNICEF has also provided technical assistance to enable scale up of the 'Nutrition Improvement through Cash and Health Education', an integrated social protection programme to improve nutrition and early childhood outcomes. Key to maintaining coverage levels, including through NICHE, is the use of innovation and technology through which UNICEF helped to develop an 'On Demand Registration' tool to enable households to dynamically register for social protection programmes without waiting for mass registration exercises. Using the tool, 12,000 new households were enrolled into NICHE in 2024 alone.

To ensure the social protection system provides more timely assistance to existing recipients and can expand to temporarily reach other vulnerable households, in 2024 UNICEF helped GoK trial how existing social protection programmes can be linked to early warning indicators. This enables anticipatory action, scaling up support before the full impacts of a shock are felt, thereby limiting the impact of negative coping mechanisms while meeting the multiple needs of children, including protection and nutrition. Further, in response to bottlenecks in child protection service delivery due to limited social service workforce capacity, UNICEF has collaborated with local government counterparts to review county budget processes and conduct comprehensive policy and financial analysis, as well as costing exercises. This led to an increase in the domestic budget for child-critical services, including a 10 per cent increase in the workforce, benefiting both displaced and host communities. This level of collaboration with local government is critical to sustainability of strengthened social protection systems at implementation level.

Across its work, UNICEF has paid specific attention to the needs of vulnerable groups such as displaced populations, women and adolescent girls, and persons with disabilities. For example, through the Netherlands-funded PROSPECTS Partnership, UNICEF, UNHCR and ILO are working to better reflect and respond to the need of refugees and host communities in Garissa and Turkana counties with county-level social protection policies as part of the NSNP. This county-level work in Garissa and Turkana also contributed to a national gender assessment of the NSNP's social assistance schemes, including but not limited to Orphans and Vulnerable Children cash transfers and NICHE to better reflect the needs of women and girls. UNICEF is also supporting GoK and partners including the World Bank to launch an adolescent-centred programme through NSNP, aimed at improving poverty conditions, school attendance and economic opportunities, especially for adolescent girls.

Finally, to advance disability-inclusive social protection, UNICEF has been working with GoK and Organizations of Persons with Disabilities to enhance access to disability assessments and registration in humanitarian crises and developing an integrated Unpaid Care and Support model, so that more children and families can access appropriate disability-inclusive and gender-responsive services. The Unpaid Care and Support model is part of a global joint programme implemented by the Global Disability Fund, UNDP, UN Women, OHCHR, UNFPA, ILO and UNICEF to understand and dismantle the multiple barriers faced by persons with disabilities as well as women and girls, in achieving economic justice and accessing necessary inclusive care and support services.

Strengthening delivery of social protection systems in fragile and humanitarian settings

By 2024, 107 countries reported having social protection systems, including cash transfers, with a medium to high capacity to respond effectively and quickly to humanitarian crises. Of these, 26 countries indicated a high level of capacity, meeting this year's milestone. As more countries invest in enhancing the preparedness of their social protection systems, the number of countries with absent or nascent systems continues to decline. In 2024, UNICEF collaborated with FCDO, BMZ, USAID, World Bank and WFP to organize the Forum on Social Protection in fragility and conflict²⁵ to highlight that work on social protection is possible in fragile and conflict settings, contrary to popular perception, and to identify key lessons and gaps drawing from country experience. At the forum, 150 practitioners from over 40 countries agreed on a common charter for action on the topic.

UNICEF has played a pivotal role in advancing the integration of social protection within climate action strategies. Following a successful advocacy at COP28, UNICEF led efforts to incorporate adaptive social protection into climate finance discussions, collaborating with BMZ and the World Bank to champion its inclusion at COP29. The organization also secured the integration of social protection as a core principle in the Baku Guiding Principles on Human Development for Climate Resilience.²⁶ As a key member of the Task Force on Adaptive Social Protection and Climate Finance, UNICEF contributed to the development of strategic guidance²⁷ that empowers countries to incorporate social protection into their Nationally Determined Contributions, ensuring alignment with climate resilience goals.

In parallel, UNICEF has been at the forefront of efforts to bridge the gap between humanitarian assistance and social protection. As co-leader of the Social Protection Inter-Agency Cooperation Board (SPIAC-B) working group,²⁸ UNICEF has united stakeholders across the donor, United Nations and international non-governmental organization communities to create synergies between these sectors. In 2024, the group developed a series of actionable tipsheets²⁹ designed to help stakeholders strengthen the linkage between social protection and humanitarian action, ensuring continuity of investments in children's development even in crisis contexts.

To build the necessary capacity for these efforts, UNICEF is employing a dual approach. This includes a partnership with the Norwegian Refugee Council's CashCap facility to enhance the expertise of humanitarian professionals in social protection, equipping them to implement these strategies in their respective countries. Simultaneously, UNICEF is developing a comprehensive training package for government counterparts, focused on enhancing the effectiveness of humanitarian cash transfers. These

initiatives are designed to ensure that the integration of social protection into humanitarian, development and peace frameworks is both sustainable and impactful.

At country level, UNICEF supported expanding coverage in these contexts, including through integrating information systems and strengthening registries to enable scale up of the social protection system in crisis situations. In Chad, UNICEF collaborated with WFP and the World Bank to include 25,000 vulnerable households in the Unified Social Registry and improve its ability to adapt to crises, while in the Dominican Republic, SIUBEN, the unified system of beneficiaries, was leveraged to identify affected households and deliver temporary cash transfers to flood-affected households. In Madagascar, work has expanded to make the social registry more shock responsive by adding indicators on climate change.

UNICEF also ensured comprehensive support by improving the design of programmes and combining social assistance with complementary services to achieve human development outcomes for children and to build resilience to shocks and stresses. In Ethiopia, UNICEF collaborated with the Ministry of Women and Social Affairs and regional bureaus to deliver cash transfers to 31,249 households impacted by conflict and climate change in eight regions. In all of these regions, cash transfers to 2,214 households were combined with training on financial literacy and life skills to enhance incomes and build resilience.

UNICEF supported countries to better prepare their social protection systems for timely assistance by linking with crisis triggers, improving planning, fostering coordination across humanitarian and social protection stakeholders, and reinforcing the public finance system in these contexts. In Cambodia, a shock responsive pillar was introduced in the IDPoor programme, covering 639,000 vulnerable households to address climate-induced and economic shocks.

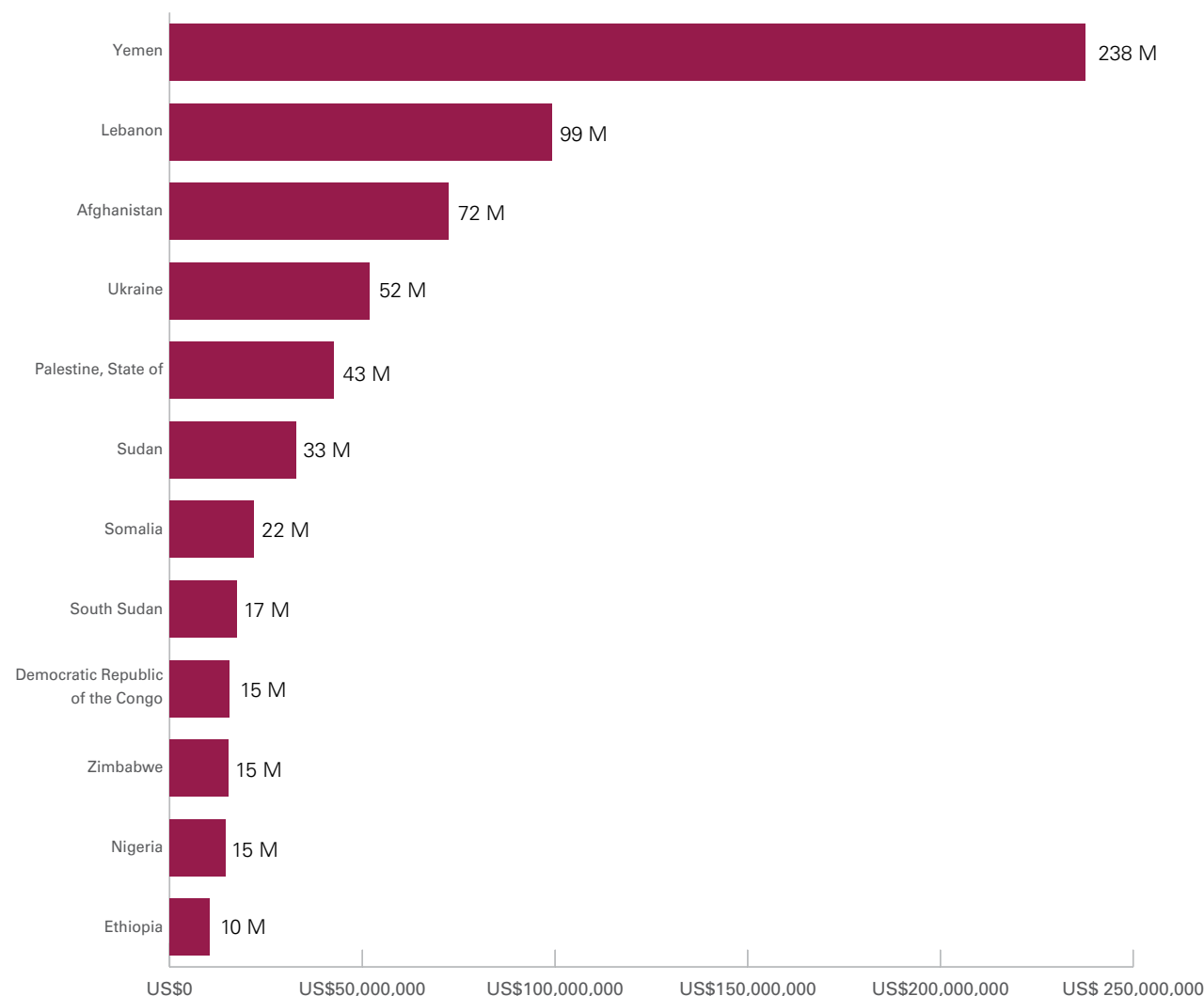
As a critical component, countries were supported to facilitate access to social protection through strengthening the social service workforce, applying innovative solutions to deliver assistance discreetly and efficiently, and working on clear communication mechanisms and strong feedback loop. In Armenia, UNICEF partnered with the Ministry of Labor and Social Affairs and the Enterprise Incubator Foundation to develop a mobile chatbot, based on Telegram. This chatbot supports refugees to navigate social protection programmes by simplifying complex processes, thus significantly reducing waiting times and easing the strain on the main hotline. Additionally, an e-wallet system was leveraged to deliver cash assistance to transfer cash assistance efficiently and transparently.

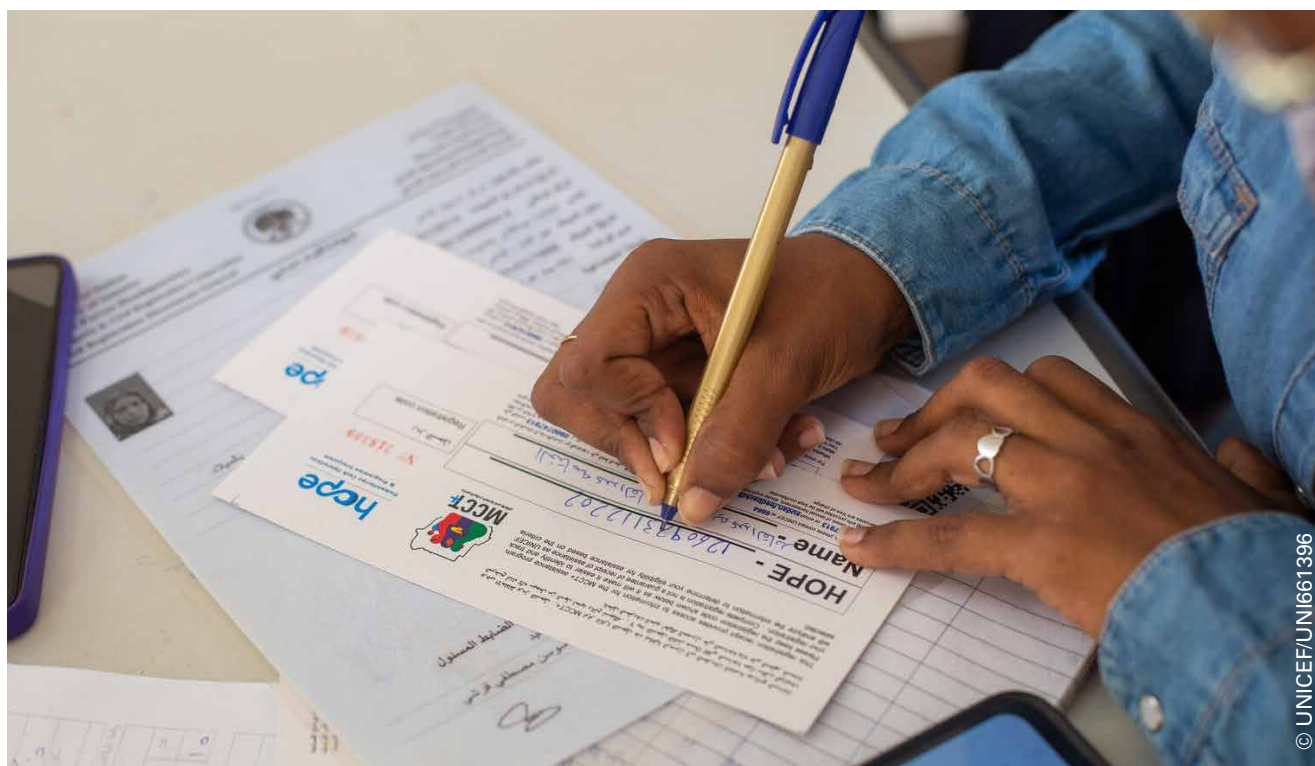
Cash-based assistance in fragile and humanitarian settings

UNICEF continued to scale the use of cash-based assistance in fragile and humanitarian settings, with US\$689 million delivered to 3.5 million families, covering 15.5 million children, in 48 countries (see Figure 6). Of the US\$689 million, approximately US\$8 million (1 per cent) was delivered as vouchers in seven countries and US\$548 million (80 per cent) was delivered thanks to agreements with private sector service providers. To further strengthen UNICEF's cash preparedness, a new Global Agreement was established with the Financial Service Provider MoneyGram to facilitate the digital delivery of cash-based assistance.

UNICEF also continued to strengthen existing national social protection systems, using them to reach 63,065 families in seven countries: Belarus, Grenada, Iran, Malawi, Moldova, Republic of Mozambique and Nepal. In addition, 1,363 refugee families from Ukraine were reached in Slovakia, to support them in addressing their basic needs and accessing services. UNICEF's use of cash-based assistance remains largely focused on addressing humanitarian basic needs across sectors, including through rapid response mechanisms. These cash assistance schemes contributed to enhanced child protection and education, as well as nutrition results for children.

FIGURE 6. UNICEF humanitarian cash transfers 2024 – top 12 countries





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On 25 September 2024, pregnant women and lactating mothers are enrolled on UNICEF's Mother and Child Cash Transfer Plus an integrated social protection programme in River Nile state. Once enrolled in the programme, women receive quarterly cash payments along with antenatal and postnatal care, nutrition services for their children, child protection and other essential services until their child reaches two years of age.

Cash-based assistance at scale in L3 emergencies and fragile contexts

UNICEF remains the main organization to continuously sustain cash assistance in the State of Palestine, delivering US\$42.6 million to 1 million people, including 2,000 families with at least one child or adult with a disability and 23,203 families with pregnant women and breastfeeding mothers. In 2024 in Syria, UNICEF delivered US\$11.5 million to 48,331 highly vulnerable families to help to address the socioeconomic and political situation across the country. Quarterly cash transfers were provided to families caring for children living with a disability, as well as to vulnerable families living in areas prone to winter hazards to ensure access to warm clothes and to meet their basic needs. In Sudan, UNICEF continued to implement its flagship Mother and Child Cash Transfer Plus programme, providing around US\$33 million in cash benefits to 96,516 families, reaching approximately 290,000 children. The programme enabled pregnant and lactating women and their children to meet their basic needs and access an integrated package of essential services, including antenatal and postnatal care, nutrition support and birth registration. In Haiti, UNICEF's cash assistance was a critical component of its humanitarian response. UNICEF worked jointly with WFP

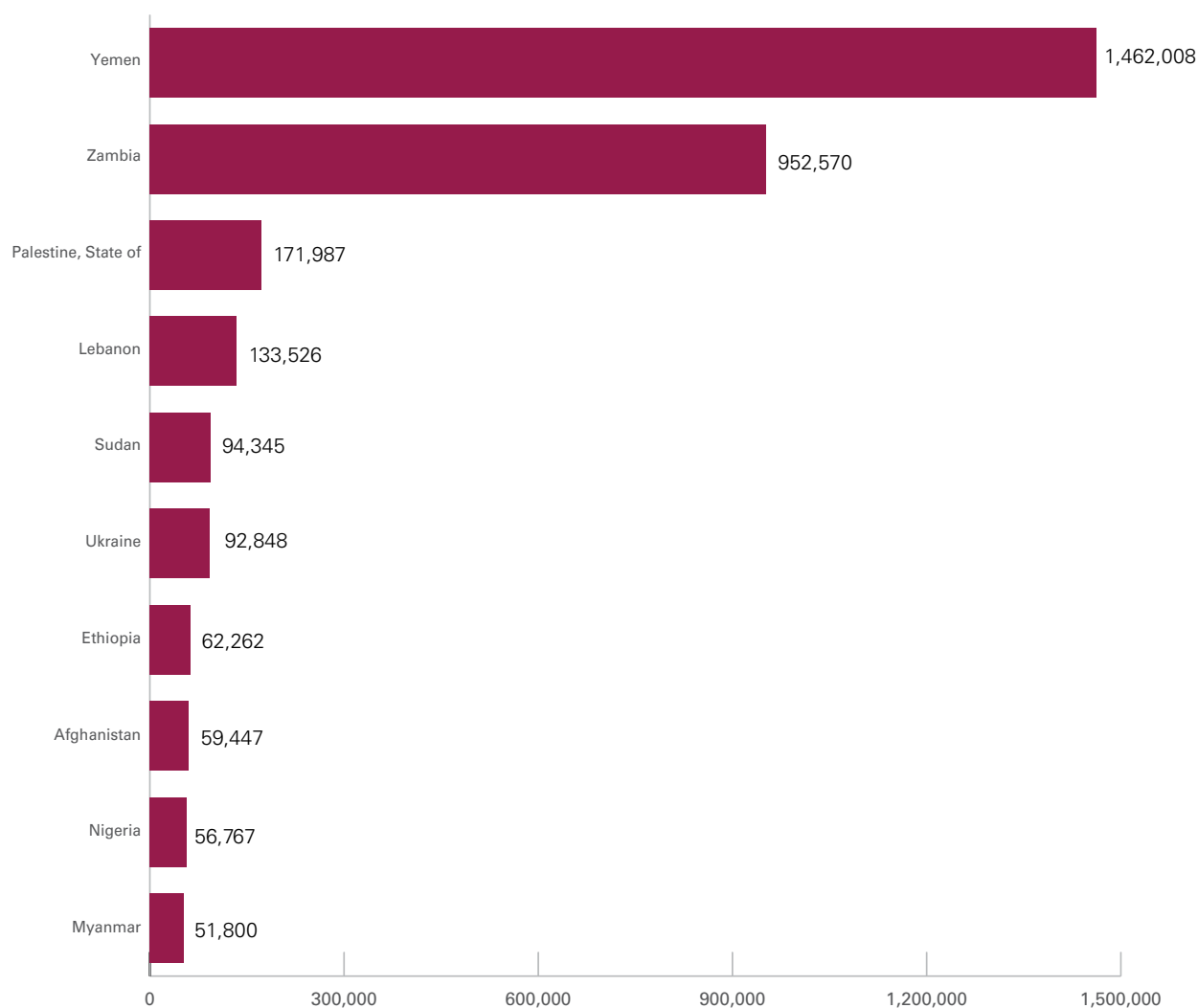
and the Ministries of Social Affairs, Labor, Humanitarian Affairs and Education to provide a total of US\$3.3 million to 11,532 vulnerable families, including over 20,000 children to help them meet their basic needs and access education and health services.

In the Democratic Republic of the Congo, UNICEF has continued to use cash-based assistance across its programmatic sectors, reaching 30,037 families with approximately US\$5 million in 2024. This work involved piloting innovative cash programmes, including a humanitarian cash transfer/shock-responsive social protection cash transfer programme for the prevention of malnutrition, and a large-scale project with the aim to prevent, mitigate and respond to gender-based violence in Eastern Democratic Republic of the Congo. In close collaboration with the Government in Lebanon, UNICEF provided emergency cash top-ups to 10,000 families (43,000 people) through the National Disability Allowance scheme. Additionally, UNICEF supported the Government in the launch of the Emergency Disability Benefit programme, ensuring all families with children and adults with disabilities received urgent financial assistance. Approximately 44,000 families (200,000 individuals) were reached.

In Armenia, UNICEF worked closely with the Ministry of Labor and Social Affairs to support refugee families living in the country. Over the course of the year, UNICEF delivered a total of US\$2.0 million to 14,335 families with young children under 9 years of age. Value vouchers were provided for purchasing clothing, as well as medication in pharmacies. In addition, 2,398 pregnant refugee mothers with children under 2 years of age were supported with vouchers to cover additional health care and nutritional needs. In Nigeria, UNICEF continued to implement its country-wide cash strategy, which includes reaching a total of 56,767 families, covering 317,895 children, with

US\$3.9 million to support families accessing basic services and cover basic needs. The responses included a Cash + Nutrition intervention in Yobe, as well as responses in severely affected flood zones. In Yemen, UNICEF continued to implement the unconditional cash transfer programme, reaching 1,462,008 families with US\$ 131 million. In addition, to address the economic and access barriers to inpatient services for children suffering from severe and acute malnutrition, 6,461 children with severe and acute malnutrition in 15 UNICEF-supported Therapeutic Feeding Centres were provided with nutrition vouchers.

FIGURE 7. Number of families reached with UNICEF humanitarian cash transfers, 2024 – top 10 countries



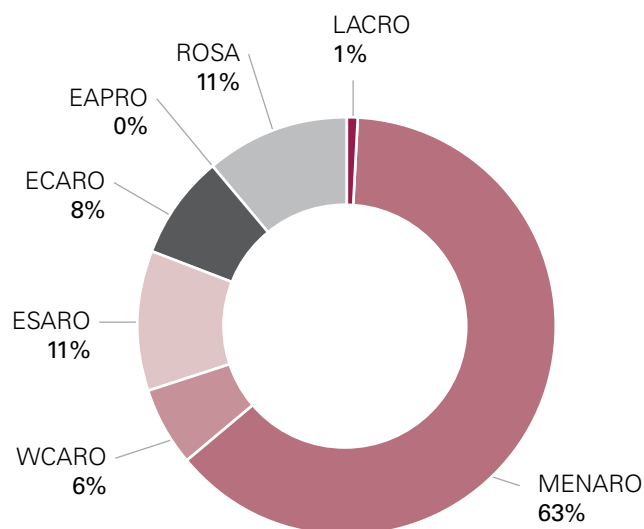
Preparedness and operational capacity

Being prepared is key to using cash-based assistance effectively on a large scale. UNICEF tested a flood-based system in the Terai region of Nepal to provide cash support quickly when floods are expected. This system worked thanks to the Global Flood Awareness System, flood warnings from Nepal's Department of Hydrology and Meteorology and UNICEF's Humanitarian cash Operations and Programme Ecosystem (HOPE) system. Families living in flood-prone areas were registered before the monsoon season and cash was set aside in advance. Once the flood warning was triggered, families received cash directly into their bank accounts within a week, with notifications sent via text message. In total, 3,601 families received US\$ 0.3 million in assistance.

To ensure that it can continue to deliver cash-based assistance in a risk-informed and efficient manner, UNICEF has continued to grow its in-house capacity through the roll-out of the organization-wide training strategy. Close to 276 UNICEF staff from 34 country offices, including 3 regional offices (Europe and Central Asia, in ECAR, Eastern and Southern Africa, and West and Central Africa) were trained in 2024. Expertise was also strengthened at headquarters with a targeted training for humanitarian focal points, aiming to strengthen the understanding and technical know-how around using cash-based assistance for sector specific objectives. (see figure 8)

Throughout the year, UNICEF continued to strengthen its operational capacity to deliver humanitarian cash transfers in a risk-informed manner, either through government systems or direct delivery. UNICEF's digital solution to manage beneficiary data information, HOPE, has continued to grow with new deployments in Bangladesh, Belarus, Madagascar, Mali, Niger, South Sudan, Syria and Vietnam in 2024. The HOPE system was strengthened over the course of the year with the integration of face recognition technologies specifically for the deduplication process, building an automated system to flag potential identity duplicates. A significant milestone was achieved when the code used to build HOPE became available publicly as an open-source product, allowing its software libraries to be used free of charge. This allows the wider humanitarian community to develop tailored software libraries, as needed, paving the way for HOPE to become a Digital Public Good³⁰ in the future.

FIGURE 8. Regional distribution of UNICEF humanitarian cash transfers, 2024



EAPRO, East Asia and Pacific Regional Office; ECARO, Europe and Central Asia Regional Office; ESARO, Eastern and Southern Africa Regional Office; LACRO, Latin America and Caribbean Regional Office; MENARO, Middle East and North Africa Regional Office; ROSA, Regional Office for South Asia; WCARO, West and Central Africa Regional Office.

Interagency collaborations for scale, impact and efficiency

UNICEF continued to strengthen its cash technical support to UNICEF-led clusters, allowing clusters to use cash transfers in more predictable and coherent manner, as part of humanitarian responses with a strengthened human-centred approach, including the development of required technical tools and guidance. UNICEF has continued to actively engage in the Cash Advisory Group. As part of this work, UNICEF financially supported the preliminary review of the new cash coordination model. UNICEF has also continued its leadership as co-lead of the SPIAC-B working group, linking humanitarian cash assistance and social protection. The working group aims to inform actions for more effective progress in linking Humanitarian Assistance and Social Protection,³¹ presenting an important framework for all actors working on the Humanitarian-Development-Peace Nexus.

Case Study 4: Scaling cash assistance to protect vulnerable women and children from climate-related shocks in Bangladesh

Bangladesh faces severe impacts from climate change, with increasing climate-related disasters, particularly flooding, which affects nearly 18 per cent of the country annually. In May 2024, Cyclone Remal displaced 18.4 million people across 45 per cent of districts. Pregnant and lactating women are especially vulnerable, with 64 per cent of health-care and nutrition services disrupted by cyclone Remal. While the Government provides cash assistance to pregnant and lactating women, recurring climate shocks highlight the need for additional support. UNICEF and partners have planned ahead by prepositioning data and contracts with financial service providers.

To address these challenges, UNICEF piloted humanitarian cash assistance for women impacted by cyclones and flash floods. The programme focused on protecting children during the first 1,000 days of life, prioritizing highly vulnerable households, including those with persons with disabilities, women-headed families and children under five years of age. Towards the end of the year, with no flooding incidents in the past 35 years, two episodes of flash flooding hit the eastern regions of the country. UNICEF leveraged its expertise in humanitarian cash-based assistance to rapidly scale its cash assistance programme to provide immediate relief. The cash-based assistance supported pregnant women and mothers with children under two years of age across 14 districts. Each eligible woman received a one-time cash payment of US\$51, covering 60 per cent of the national Minimum Expenditure Basket. A total of 16,685 women were reached within 84 hours, disbursing a total of over US\$1.2 million through mobile money, which could be redeemed at local stores. This volume was delivered over two humanitarian responses over the course of the year.

Post-distribution monitoring surveys conducted by UNICEF showed that 43 per cent of the cash received was spent on purchasing health items and medication, 21 per cent on buying food, and 15 per cent on appointments at health facilities. The remaining 21 per cent was spent on various items, such as transportation costs, house and latrine repairs, clothes and debt repayment. This programme demonstrated UNICEF's capacity to respond swiftly to climate-related crises and the critical role of UNICEF's HOPE in ensuring an efficient, secure and transparent cash transfer process. The system, which manages the personal data of 109,000 people across the country, enabled rapid registration and verification of beneficiaries. By leveraging this digital platform, UNICEF ensured that families in need received assistance in a timely and effective manner. The cash assistance provided also helped to mitigate negative coping mechanisms such as child labour, early marriage and school dropout.

Beyond immediate emergency relief, the programme has contributed to strengthening Bangladesh's national social protection system. Data gathered through the initiative has been integrated into the government's database for the national Mother and Child Benefit Programme, improving its responsiveness to climate-related shocks. The intervention also revealed critical gaps in existing social protection policies, particularly for young mothers under 18 years of age, who are often victims of child marriage and excluded from government programmes. By generating evidence on the most vulnerable populations, UNICEF is advocating for policy reforms to expand social protection coverage and ensure that all mothers and children receive the support they need.



Lucia Juma, a beneficiary of a social cash transfer programme and her 3 month old baby Prince Patrick, Malawi.

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Spotlight on the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund 2024



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UNICEF works across 12 of the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) to bring about positive change for children. The Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund makes vital contributions to SDG 1: End poverty in all its forms everywhere, and SDG 10: Reduce inequality within and among countries.

1. UNICEF's Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund: Ensuring access to inclusive social protection and lives free from poverty

Millions of children around the world live in poverty and experience poverty across multiple dimensions – lacking the resources they need to meet their basic needs, but also equitable access to services such as health care, education and protection. Growing up without these necessities has consequences that can last a lifetime, leaving children vulnerable to poverty and limiting their opportunities to escape poverty as adults.

Despite this urgent need, investment across the social sectors, including social protection, remains insufficient: many countries allocate less than 2 per cent of their gross domestic product (GDP) to social protection measures that protect children and families from poverty.

UNICEF is committed to changing this. By offering policy solutions on comprehensive and inclusive social protection programming and transforming public finance management to leverage more investments for children, UNICEF ensures that governments around the world are well equipped to end child poverty.

The Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund powers this work. With flexible, multi-year funding, the Fund is not just ensuring access to cash; it is driving

systemic change that reduces deprivation and builds fairer, more inclusive societies for children everywhere, while enhancing their resilience to economic and climate-related shocks.

“Social protection changes lives. Thanks to our partners, UNICEF is helping countries build stronger systems that reach every child, especially those who are most excluded. Your flexible contributions are investments in equity, resilience and lasting results.”

Kitty van der Heijden, Deputy Executive Director, Partnerships, UNICEF

2. Financial results

Investment catalysing progress for generations

Investments in social protection are proven to deliver far-reaching returns, lifting families out of poverty, boosting local economies and protecting the futures of generations of children.

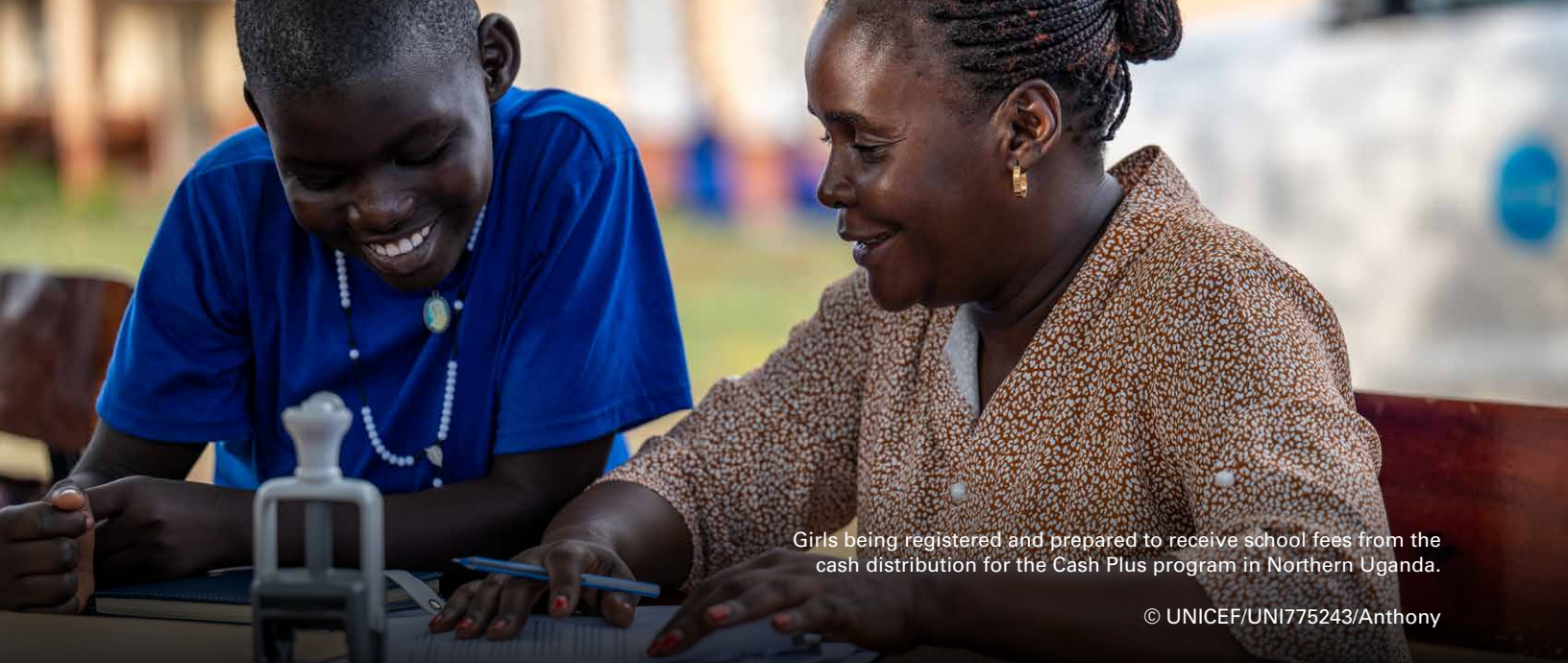
In 2024, the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund mobilized US\$0.8 million in contributions from partners. UNICEF extends special thanks to the Government of Spain, a key advocate and long-standing champion in ending child poverty, for its instrumental support to the Fund.

Top Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund partners by contributions received, 2024^a

Sector	Donor	Amount (US\$)
Public	Spain	809,061
Grand total		809,061



^a The thematic funding contributions relate to the Strategic Plan 2022–2025.



Girls being registered and prepared to receive school fees from the cash distribution for the Cash Plus program in Northern Uganda.

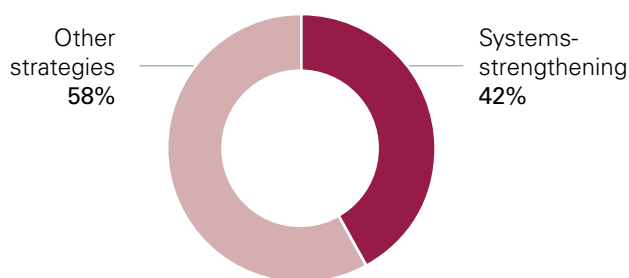
© UNICEF/UNI775243/Anthony

Why flexible funding matters

What makes the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund uniquely powerful is not just where the money goes, but how it works. Because contributions are flexible and invested over the four-year period of UNICEF's Strategic Plan (2022–2025), UNICEF is empowered to be an impact catalyst – helping countries strengthen their social systems, scale proven concepts, unlock additional resources and maximize the returns for children.

In 2024, UNICEF incurred US\$0.6million in flexible thematic funding expense from the Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund. Every dollar spent moved UNICEF closer to the vision of a world where national systems accelerate children's rights to social security and an adequate standard of living.

UNICEF expense by programme strategy, 2024



In 2024, 42 per cent of Social Policy and Social Protection thematic funding was spent on strengthening social systems ensuring that children live free from poverty.

Note: The category 'other' consists of strategies that enable systems-strengthening, including advocacy and communications; social and behaviour change; data and research; digital transformation; innovation; partnerships and engagement; and support to programme delivery.

A call to scale: What works

Child poverty is not inevitable – it is a consequence of suboptimal policy choices and inefficient or ineffective sectoral systems that fail to address the basic needs of the most vulnerable. Achieving the SDGs means reaching the poorest children and transforming the structures and systems, including the policy frameworks and availing finances, that protect them from poverty and exclusion.

The Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund is UNICEF's most strategic mechanism to support governments to make the right policy choices to end child poverty. With flexible, predictable funding, UNICEF can go further and faster and work more strategically where the need is greatest: supporting reform and ensuring that children living in poverty are visible, prioritized and protected, and that investments are available to address their basis needs.

We know what works. Now is the time to scale it. We call on partners to help make this vision a reality: a world where social protection is a right, not a privilege, and every child has the support they need to survive, thrive and fulfil their potential.



Transparency with Thematic Funding

UNICEF has a strong financial transparency record, including for thematic funding. We encourage UNICEF partners to the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund to visit the Transparency Portal and access real-time information on spending in the countries receiving funds.

3. The footprint of the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund

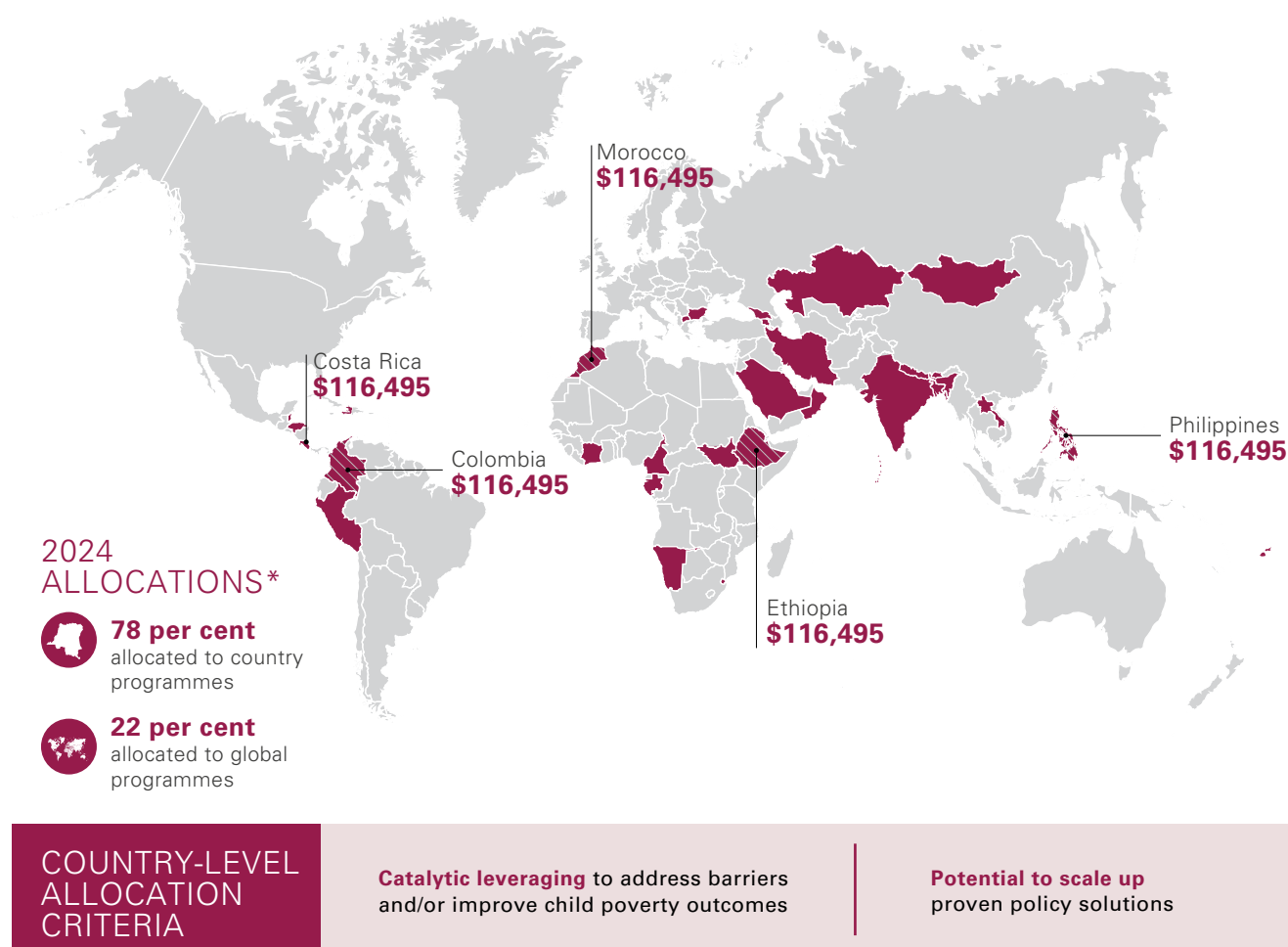
The reach of the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund spans across regions, delivering impact across three interconnected levels:

- At the **country level**: Investments make children living in poverty visible, support national social protection systems and scale up social protection schemes, including cash transfer programmes, and targeted interventions where children's needs are greatest.
- At the **regional level**: Investments strengthen technical expertise, foster cross-country collaboration and accelerate the expansion of best practices.

- At the **global level**: Investments support UNICEF's technical and thought leadership in measuring child poverty, developing the tools, policy guidance and financing mechanisms to reduce child poverty, and strengthening inclusive, resilient systems everywhere.

This layered model ensures UNICEF can drive sustainable, system-wide improvements in equity, resilience and safeguarding the rights of every child, everywhere.

THE Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund allocations around the world²



Note: The map is stylized and not to scale. It does not reflect a position by UNICEF on the legal status of any country or area or the delimitation of any frontiers

² The map shows all countries that received allocations from the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund between 2022 and 2024. The allocations in 2024 are shown with full amounts.

Why focus on systems-strengthening?

UNICEF's systems-strengthening model enables us to sustainably scale up services and shield more children from poverty. We support more equitable and inclusive access to essential social protection schemes, and the scale-up of these schemes, including cash and other support, can reach all children and families in need. We also support stronger integration of administrative systems, ensuring that social protection delivery mechanisms address children's issues. Finally, we ensure the preparedness of social protection systems to withstand climate and economic shocks. Our efforts are anchored in:

- **Data and evidence:** UNICEF supports countries to generate critical data and evidence on child poverty to inform decision-making and help monitor social policy and social protection programmes.
- **Legal and policy change:** UNICEF supports countries to improve national laws, policies and strategies that protect children from poverty and promote their long-term well-being.
- **Public finance:** UNICEF ensures that transparent and equitable budget policies and adequate public and private financing mechanisms are in place to deliver social services, including for increased social protection coverage to reduce poverty.

4. From Programmes to policy: A systems shift to end child poverty

The scale of unmet need in social protection is profound, but so is UNICEF's ambition. Across all regions, the Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund is helping countries shift from fragmented programmes to inclusive, integrated systems that tackle child poverty at its roots and protect children throughout their lives.

In 2024, through the systems-strengthening model, thematic funding enabled UNICEF to drive progress across three priorities:

- **Child poverty reduction:** Making children living in poverty visible and reforming policy solutions and legal frameworks to make them sensitive to children's needs
- **Public finance for children (PF4C):** Supporting governments to invest in what matters most: the survival, development and protection of children
- **Social protection:** Supporting countries to ensure social protection programmes are gender-responsive, disability-inclusive and adaptive to shocks.

This not only improved the coverage and inclusiveness of social protection programmes, but how children's rights are financed, protected and prioritized across social sectors and

societies. Below are some headline sector results for which thematic funding, as part of a broader portfolio of funding, was a key contributor.

Systems-strengthening: Child poverty reduction

Reliable data and strong evidence are at the heart of effective child poverty reduction. UNICEF works closely with governments to generate and apply robust analysis, ensuring that policies and programmes are rooted in reality and responsive to the needs of children and families.

In 2024, progress accelerated across all major data and evidence areas:

- At the **global level**, UNICEF finalized its Child Poverty Advocacy Strategy, changing the narrative around eradicating child poverty, to generate greater political leadership and commitment, both in recognition of the urgency of child poverty and in the implementation and financing of policies that accelerate progress – a major step towards ending child poverty worldwide.



Bakari Konate in the village of Soria, in Mali, with his daughter Daloba Konate, and his wife. “I always wanted my daughter to go to school, but I lacked the means. Thanks to the money I received, I bought school supplies, clothes, and shoes for my daughter. Today, my daughter is back in school. I’m really happy, as is my wife.

© UNICEF/UNI595496/Keita

Country-level investments, supported by the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund, have put these data to work to expand service coverage and drive inclusion:

- In **Costa Rica**, UNICEF partnered with the National Institute for Social Care to strengthen data interoperability and drive evidence-informed policy. Together, they enhanced the country’s ability to track service delivery, respond to family needs in real time, and improve targeting for the most vulnerable children. The partnership also helped assess gaps in early childhood services and supported efforts to increase women’s workforce participation by improving access to social support and childcare.
- In **Kazakhstan**, the government adopted the National Development Plan, which introduced the multidimensional poverty index, reflecting long-standing UNICEF advocacy. This will expand poverty measures beyond income to include access to education, health care and social protection.

Through these efforts, UNICEF is helping countries move from data to action – designing smarter policies, reaching children who are most at risk, and building more efficient, equitable systems for the future.

Systems-strengthening: Public finance for children

Lasting change requires guaranteed support for the most vulnerable and equitable public spending. UNICEF works with governments to ensure children are prioritized in national budgeting and helps secure long-term public investment so that social protection becomes a lasting commitment rather than a temporary measure. The Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund plays a key role in these efforts, enabling UNICEF to drive policy change and system reform across diverse contexts:

- In **Colombia**, UNICEF designed and implemented new financing instruments based on public-private partnerships and the structuring of territorial investment projects for the development of inclusive comprehensive care routes focused on children with disabilities and early childhood. A study supported by UNICEF on the costs of goods and services facilitated inclusive education for children living with disabilities and made recommendations to ensure the necessary financing in national and territorial programmes.



Makama Marguerite, mother of 12 children, smiles as she holds the mobile phone she has just received in Kabalo, Tanganyika province, the Democratic Republic of the Congo. Thanks to this phone, she will receive monthly cash assistance to combat malnutrition.

© UNICEF/UNI605920/Mulala

- In **South Sudan**, with UNICEF support, subnational authorities, Parliament, partners and civil society organizations are now equipped with knowledge and skills to advocate for budget reform. UNICEF provided subnational public financial management support and produced key advocacy and evidence-based documents, including national and subnational budget briefs and an investment case for the education sector – a key stepping stone towards increasing allocations in this sector.
- In **Namibia**, UNICEF's advocacy in public financial management has yielded significant outcomes. Namibia's budget transparency score improved markedly from 42 in 2021 to 54 in 2023, while citizen participation in budgeting increased from 0 to 20 out of 100, reflecting a move towards inclusivity and accountability in budgeting processes – a key step towards achieving improved development outcomes for children and families.
- In **Côte d'Ivoire**, UNICEF built the capacity of 180 adolescents, youth and community leaders in 9 municipalities to influence local budgets and trained 50 local development committee members on child-sensitive budgeting, paving the way for scaling up participatory budgeting in a decentralized context. A study on child multidimensional poverty was also undertaken, ensuring the availability of evidence to guide public policy. Findings reveal that 8.6 million

children (representing 62.5 per cent of those under the age of 18) are affected by multidimensional poverty, particularly in the areas of housing, health and sanitation. These data serve as a strategic foundation for better targeting interventions and sustainably improving children's living conditions.

- In the **Republic of Cameroon**, UNICEF advocated for the protection and expansion of inclusive investments for children, ensuring that social sector funding remains secure even during economic challenges, leading to a 5 per cent increase in social sector spending.

Systems-strengthening: Social protection

A strong social protection system leaves no child vulnerable to economic hardship and social exclusion. UNICEF works hand in hand with governments to expand inclusive social protection systems.

UNICEF's technical support through the Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund has been critical in helping countries expand coverage and reach the most vulnerable:

- In the **Maldives**, UNICEF undertook a budgetary analysis on social protection. The findings and recommendations have helped support UNICEF's

advocacy to the government to introduce a universal family allowance to streamline the social protection system, consolidating the single-parent, foster care disability (children) and care allowances, and provide the necessary evidence to inform future policymaking.

- In **Morocco**, UNICEF continued its policy and budget advocacy for universal and adequate social protection coverage. UNICEF also supported the Ministry of Economy and Finance in conducting critical fiscal analysis on the sustainability of social protection programmes and designing the national agency responsible for managing the implementation and scale-up of the child benefit programme which is reaching 80 per cent of the country's child population.
- In **Ethiopia**, UNICEF and partners expanded the child grant pilot to the Oromia region, reaching an additional 302 households. Each household received two rounds of bi-monthly cash transfers amounting to ETB 8,000 (approximately US\$59.20). Beyond financial support, the programme has significantly improved child health outcomes:
 - 163 of 188 children under one year have been vaccinated, and 177 have received immunization cards.
 - Preparations are under way to provide birth certificates to all eligible children during the third disbursement round.
 - All mothers and caregivers of children under one year have participated in at least one social and behaviour change session focused on young child feeding practices.
- In **Georgia**, UNICEF completed three key studies on social protection, generating the critical data and evidence needed to ensure more inclusive, shock-responsive social protection systems for children. Stakeholders, including the government, now have an improved understanding of the importance of budgetary allocations, helping to advance discussions on inclusive and equitable social protection measures. By the end of 2024, more than 270,700 children, representing 32.2 per cent of Georgia's child population, benefited from cash assistance through the Targeted Social Assistance programme, compared to more than 250,500 in 2023 (27.8 per cent of the child population).
- In **Mongolia**, UNICEF's support and advocacy to the government has helped ensure equitable access to social protection by enhancing enrolment, particularly among marginalized children, and sustaining support for the child allowance. As a result, coverage will increase to 1.33 million children in 2025, up from 1.30 million in 2024, with the budget increasing from MNT 1,540.9 billion to MNT 1,580.2 billion, reflecting continued commitment to financial resilience amidst inflation.

This is the power of social protection: lifting families out of poverty and connecting them to the systems that protect, nourish and empower them.

Results that last

Systems-strengthening is a long-term investment – but one that delivers transformative returns.

In 2024, flexible thematic funding through the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund contributed to major global gains, helping ensure more children grow up safe, supported and with access to opportunity.

Child poverty reduction

- **74 countries** were routinely measuring monetary child poverty in 2024, up from 63 in 2022 and 72 in 2023. 71 countries measured multidimensional child poverty, compared to 66 in 2022 and 72 in 2023.

Public finance for children

- With UNICEF's support, **93 countries** strengthened their social sector budgets in 2024, up from 66 in 2022 and 67 in 2023. These improvements are helping to unlock more and better investments in health, education and social protection for children.

Social protection

- UNICEF scaled up direct support in fragile and humanitarian contexts. In 2024, UNICEF funded cash based assistance to **3.6 million** vulnerable families – up from 2.9 million in 2023 – disbursing a total of US\$574 million through its delivery systems.

This reflects not only the scale of UNICEF's support, but the deep, systemic shifts that are under way. By strengthening laws, budgets and data systems, UNICEF and its partners are building the foundation for a world where every child can grow up free from poverty and full of possibility.



Scan the QR code or click on the image to read UNICEF's Data Companion and Scorecard for more information on progress against SDG and Strategic Plan targets. Thematic Funding as part of UNICEF's overall funding portfolio contributes to this progress.

5. Impact story

Transforming the future for children in Morocco

Turning policy into tangible results: Building a social protection system that leaves no child behind

Growing up in poverty affects children's futures in profound ways, undermining their lifelong well-being and limiting their access to health care, education and protection. Yet with strong national leadership and commitment, sound policy and strategic investment, child poverty can be reduced.

Today in Morocco, transformative progress is under way. National reforms, driven by sustained government leadership and UNICEF's decade-long partnerships with key actors such as the European Union, the World Bank and other key actors, are now helping protect more children than ever before from poverty and exclusion.

Just a few years ago, the gaps were stark. Over a quarter of children received inadequate child benefits. Today, **80 per cent of children are covered by the new national social protection programme**. This new social assistance programme seeks to streamline various previously existing social protection programmes and benefits 4.8 million children (44 per cent of the child population), providing a safety net for families in the informal sector, as well as for working families who were previously not considered poor enough to receive aid but still lacked stable social security. An additional 3.9 million children (36 per cent of the child population) continue to receive monthly cash transfers through the contributory social protection scheme.

The new social assistance programme provides for families who are identified as eligible through the national social registry

- **Monthly cash transfers** for children under 21 years
- **A lump-sum cash transfer at birth** for the first two children



- **An annual back-to-school allowance** for children under 21 years
- **Monthly supplements** for orphans, children with disabilities, and children in school
- **Monthly cash transfers for children deprived of parental care and living in institutional care.** These funds will be saved and given to the child as a lump-sum allowance when they reach the age of majority, thereby supporting their transition from the care system to independent living.

This systemic shift is helping to ensure that no child is left behind, by building strong foundations to progressively improve social protection for all and delivering tangible results for all children today, including the most vulnerable.

Since 2024, UNICEF has partnered with the government to drive the next wave of social protection reform to sustain Morocco's extraordinary progress in widely extending health insurance and child benefits. Thematic funding was instrumental in achieving two pivotal milestones: providing timely and quality **technical support for the setting up of the new national agency** managing Morocco's child benefits programme, and **conducting a comprehensive fiscal space analysis** to strengthen the long-term sustainability of the financing of the country's social protection reforms.

Every dollar invested in social protection is an investment in a child's future and a more inclusive, resilient Morocco where every child has an opportunity to develop their full potential and thrive.

"The core challenge of Morocco's social protection reform is to leave no one behind, particularly the most vulnerable children. We are hopeful that an evaluation planned for next year will help us clearly demonstrate progress in achieving inclusive coverage and impact of the new national social protection programme.

The Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund was, and is, vital to enable UNICEF to support this work. Morocco is now on the verge of achieving universal social protection coverage for all children in the country."

Laura Bill, UNICEF Morocco Representative

6. Hearing from our donors and partners

Spain and UNICEF: Advancing social protection and child poverty reduction together

In 2024, the Government of Spain reaffirmed its unique role as UNICEF's key partner to the Global Social Policy and Social Protection Thematic Fund, further solidifying its collaborative efforts.

The Government of Spain has shown unwavering support for building greater global commitment to ending child poverty, expanding inclusive social protection coverage and financing for children, and prioritizing child-sensitive investments to protect children's rights – standing with UNICEF in our shared mission to help realize the vision of a world where no child grows up in poverty, backed by Spain's flexible, multi-year funding that delivers real impact.

As UNICEF enters the last year of its Strategic Plan (2022–2025), Spain's support has been pivotal in three critical areas:

- Placing child poverty at the heart of national economic agendas
- Financing for children
- Expanding inclusive, gender-responsive social protection, even in fragile contexts.

This catalytic funding has empowered UNICEF to scale high-impact solutions, from child poverty analysis to strengthening national systems, building stronger foundations for long-term change.

With nearly a billion children trapped in multidimensional poverty, the need for equitable social policies, fiscal reform and systemic resilience has never been greater.

As global crises threaten decades of progress, the Government of Spain remains committed to ensuring no child is left behind, by investing in systems that break cycles of poverty and unlock every child's potential.



Tania Akhter (17), at her house with her younger brother in Cox Bazar, Bangladesh. Tania is a beneficiary of a UNICEF supported programme which has helped her become financially self-dependent and able to assist her family.

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Looking forward

On November 18, 2023, Ayrin Akter Asha, a 16-year-old dropout, and her family pose for a photo in Koromtoli, Pubail. In the midst of family struggles, her father considered marrying her off due to poverty during the pandemic. However, her determined mother, alongside three sisters and a brother, halted this plan.

Asha's story takes a turn when she joins UNICEF's Alternative Learning Programme (ALP). Under MCP Md. Nazim's guidance, she learnt sewing and secured a job in his mini-garment business.

Surprising her initially unwilling father, Asha now earns more than him, filling him with pride. With aspirations to be a role model for girls in similar marginalized backgrounds, Asha is breaking free from poverty, thanks to UNICEF's intervention in providing alternative learning pathways.

As 2025 begins, the global landscape for development assistance is becoming increasingly uncertain, marked by significant cuts to ODA and a tightening fiscal space for governments worldwide. These financial constraints are placing immense pressure on social programmes, particularly those focused on children's welfare and development. With fewer resources available, many countries are struggling to maintain funding for essential services including education, health care and nutrition for children. The shrinking pool of development aid is exacerbating inequalities, leaving the most vulnerable populations – especially children in low-income regions – at risk of losing access to critical support. This scenario highlights the growing challenge for international organizations and governments alike to ensure that the most disadvantaged children are not left behind in an era of economic retrenchment.

Climate change, increasing fragility and conflict, displacement and heightened vulnerabilities due to shifts in the global political landscape have collectively strained social protection systems worldwide. Social protection remains underfunded and vulnerable to competing priorities, due to challenges at the intersection of political will, fiscal constraints and financing difficulties. The reduction in ODA and the burden of debt have further limited the capacity of governments to fund and sustain robust social protection systems. As a result, government budget cuts to social sectors in several countries have led to a reduction in social protection coverage, including child benefits. These multifaceted challenges underscore the urgent need for UNICEF and partners to safeguard social protection investments, expand coverage and enhance impact by making systems more integrated, resilient, inclusive and adaptive to protect vulnerable populations and promote stability in an increasingly volatile world. With crises becoming increasingly protracted, there is greater recognition among policymakers of the important role social protection can play in a range of crisis- and risk-prone contexts. Children make up a significant proportion of those at risk, with 213 million children across 146 countries and territories estimated to be in need of humanitarian assistance in 2025.³²

In 2025, UNICEF's advocacy strategy to secure global, regional and national commitment, action and investments for evidence-based policies and programmes that are proven to accelerate ending child poverty, both monetary and multidimensional, will be rolled out. UNICEF will further explore establishing an 'Ending Child Poverty Fund', including via bilateral partners, private institutions and UNICEF National Committees, to ensure strategic alignment, accountability and results-focused implementation in accordance with UNICEF established procedures, rules and regulations.

UNICEF's Public Finances for Children programme will continue to focus on ensuring that sufficient resources are allocated for child-related policies and programmes. UNICEF will enhance monitoring social spending, analysing political economy and generating evidence to inform risk management and recovery strategies. UNICEF also will further prioritize engagement in policy dialogue to safeguard and prioritize social spending for children, especially in fragile and humanitarian settings.

To achieve scale and impact, UNICEF will work with partners to ensure the inclusion of social protection as a critical sector to shape global policies, processes, guidance and discourses. Specifically, UNICEF will work to increase support to governments, jointly with key partners, in doubling current coverage and ensuring that 1 billion children have access to child benefits by 2030. UNICEF will achieve this by drawing on experience of working on social protection system-building in a range of fragile and humanitarian contexts and leveraging the in-house expertise to maintain continuity of support. In line with this, to generate evidence and learn from the experience in a range of operating contexts to build and strengthen social protection in fragile settings, UNICEF will continue, among other collaborations, its partnership with GMZ on 'Adaptive social protection: Evidence for child outcomes in fragile settings'. Over the next five years, this partnership will be key to generate evidence through impact evaluations as well as research and share the findings to strengthen the adaptiveness of social protection systems. Moving forward, UNICEF will continue to advocate for care systems that are not only inclusive of disability, but also aligned with wider agendas on gender equality, the care economy, child rights, ageing and deinstitutionalization. UNICEF will strengthen collaboration with partners including the World Bank, OHCHR, UN Women, ILO, UNDP and the Global Disability Fund to sustain momentum gained on family-friendly policies and care and support systems.

Strengthening UNICEF's operational capacity to respond to humanitarian needs is critical. UNICEF will continue to systematically support country offices to strengthen social protection systems and deliver humanitarian cash transfers in fragile and humanitarian contexts. As such, UNICEF's global humanitarian cash transfer training strategy will continue to strengthen UNICEF staff capacity to systematically integrate a cash delivery element into their sectoral responses. To cover children's needs in a more holistic and effective manner, UNICEF will continue to institutionalize its beneficiary data management system HOPE. This will include strengthening the system to ensure it is fit to address the specific needs of country offices in a timely manner and at scale.

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Financial Annexⁱ

Glossary of key terms

Income, revenue and contributions received

- **Income:** Income includes contributions received in a given year from public sector partners (governments, including the European Commission, inter-organizational arrangements, global programme partnerships, and international financial institutions) and revenue from private sector partners. UNICEF uses income to prepare the financial framework, which forms part of the UNICEF Strategic Plan. Income is not part of the audited UNICEF financial statements.
- **Revenue:** UNICEF recognizes revenue for the full contribution agreement value when the partner agreement is signed in line with requirements of the International Public Sector Accounting Standards (IPSAS). This includes multi-year contribution agreements reflecting the full commitment of our partners for current and future years.
- **Contributions received:** Cash and contributions in kind received from resource partners within a calendar year.

Expenses and expenditures

- **Expenses** are recorded according to the International IPSAS and are accrual based. These are used for official financial reporting.
- **Expenditures** are recorded on a modified cash basis. They are used for budget reporting as they are aligned with cash disbursements and goods receipts (the way budgets are consumed).

Financial overview

Resources by type of funding

UNICEF has several funding modalities that work together to contribute to lasting impact; these include core and other resources, which include softly earmarked thematic funds, as well as tightly earmarked funds.

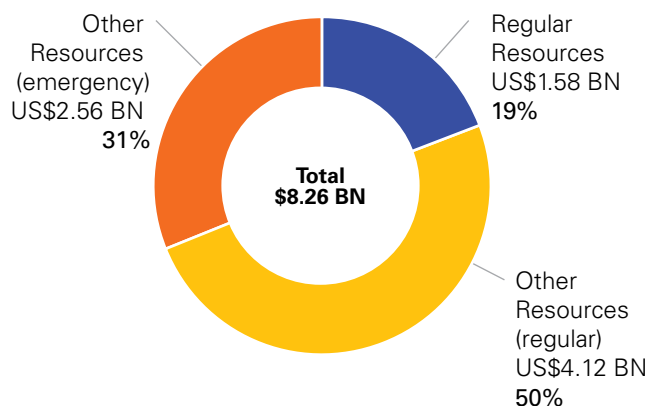
- Core Resources (RR) – contributions without restrictions within the framework of the Strategic Plan, to be used flexibly for children wherever and whenever the need is greatest.
- Other Resources Regular (ORR) – contributions that are earmarked by UNICEF partners for development programming. These can include flexible thematic funding at global, regional and country level. They can also be further earmarked for specific programmes or projects.
- Other Resources Emergency (ORE) – contributions that are earmarked by UNICEF partners for humanitarian programming. These can include flexible thematic funding for global, regional or further earmarked for specific emergency responses.

In a challenging economic climate, UNICEF's total income reached US\$8.26 billion in 2024, a 7 per cent or \$657 million decrease compared to 2023. These resources entrusted to UNICEF represent a spectrum, from funding earmarked to specific programmes to flexible funds given without any restriction to address the most pressing needs of children and to invest strategically in programming for scale, sustainability and resilience. The contributions from the public sector decreased by \$483 million compared to 2023, while private sector contributions decreased by \$221 million.

In 2024, Core Resources (RR) – UNICEF's most flexible funding – increased to 19 per cent of total income, from 18 per cent in 2023, to a total of \$1.58 billion.

The Funding Compact commitment of member states to increase core funding as share of the overall public sector and member states income fell short of the 30 per cent target in 2024. UNICEF is continuing to encourage partners to increase RR contributions as part of a broader portfolio approach across all funding types, ensuring the organization's presence globally and its ability to bring about systemic change to meet the needs of every child, everywhere.

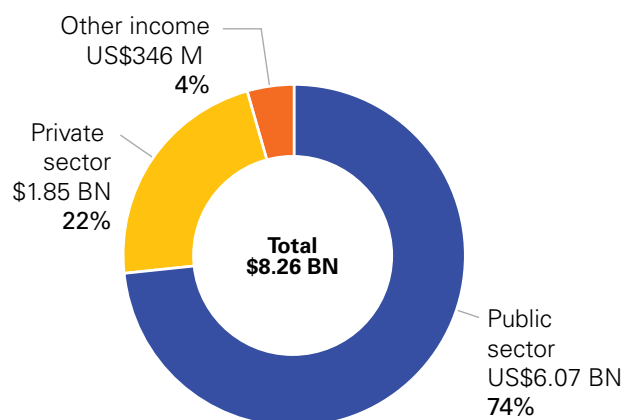
FIGURE A1: Income by type of funding, 2024



Resources by type of resource partner

In 2024, public sector income reached a \$6.07 billion, and made up 74 per cent of UNICEF's total income. Private sector income amounted to \$1.85 billion in 2024, which was 22 per cent of UNICEF's total income. Other income – including income from interest, procurement services and other sources – amounted to \$346 million or 4 per cent of UNICEF's total income.

FIGURE A2: Income by type of resource partner, 2024



Thematic funding

Thematic funds are softly earmarked pooled funds categorized as Other Resources (OR) and designed to support the achievement of results at country, regional and global levels. For partners, contributing to UNICEF's thematic funding pools enables them to champion the principles of good multilateral resource partnerships. Thematic funds deliver a higher return on investment for results for children, as their lower indirect cost recovery allows a greater share of funding to be directed toward programming, while also benefiting from transactional efficiencies compared to more tightly earmarked contributions. Thematic funding contributions continued to decline in 2024, from a record high of \$1.20 billion in 2022 (primarily driven by private sector funding for the Ukraine crisis) to \$475 million in 2023, down to \$361 million in 2024, constituting only 5 per cent of total OR. Thematic funding as a proportion of total OR from member states specifically decreased from 8 per cent in 2022 to 4 per cent in 2024, below the Funding Compact target of 15 per cent by 2027.

Private sector contributions – representing 58 per cent (\$211 million) of total thematic funding in 2024 – came from National Committees, 35 country offices and additional individual donors, including through online donations. Public sector contributions were provided by 20 governments and accounted for 42 per cent of thematic funding contributions in 2024 (\$150 million).

Apart from the spike in contributions in 2021 and 2022, largely from humanitarian private sector giving, the average level of thematic funding over the past decade has never reached more than 10 per cent of total OR contributions. UNICEF encourages partners to channel more contributions through these softly earmarked funds to allow maximum flexibility at the global, country and regional levels to strengthen results for children.

FIGURE A3: Contributions received by type of funding, 2024: Thematic vs non-thematic

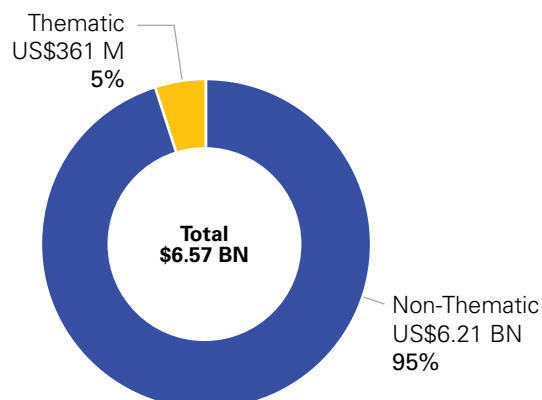


FIGURE A4: Thematic contributions received by resource partner, 2024: Public vs private

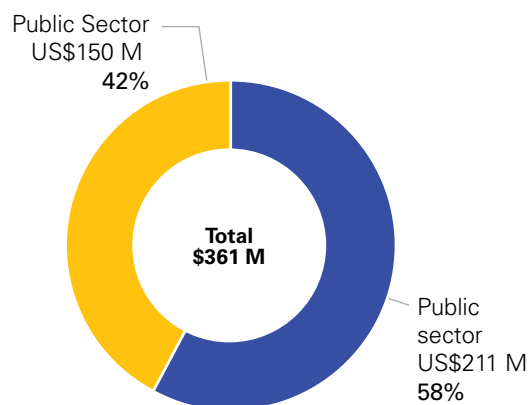
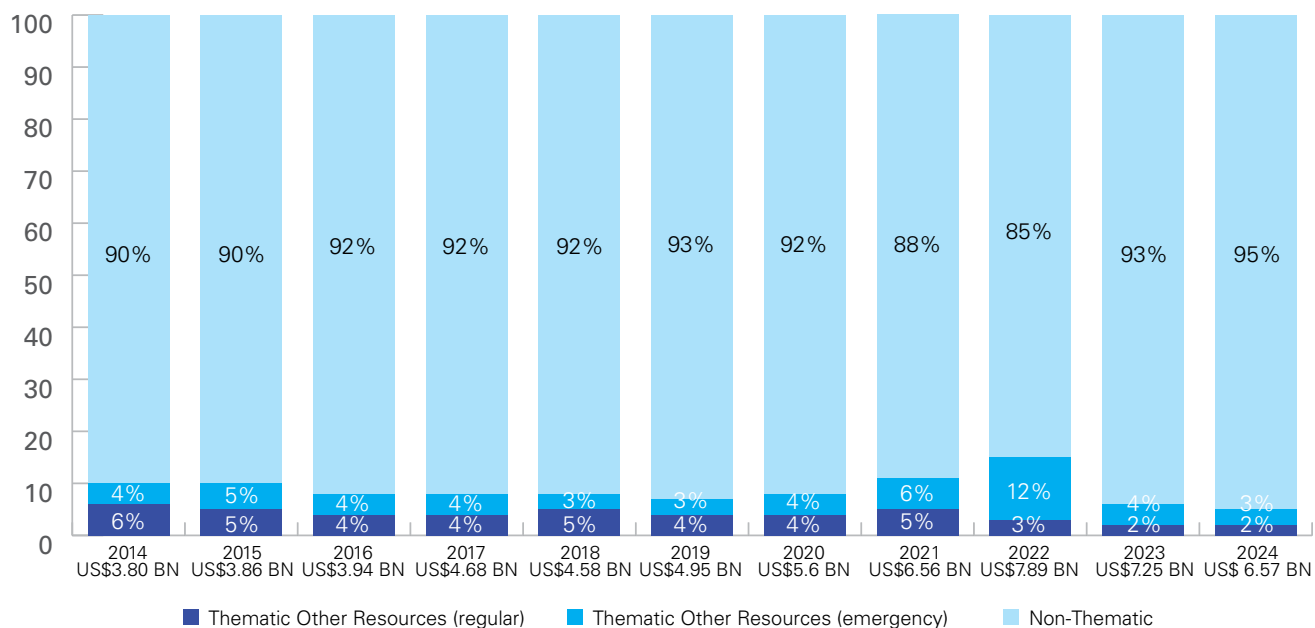
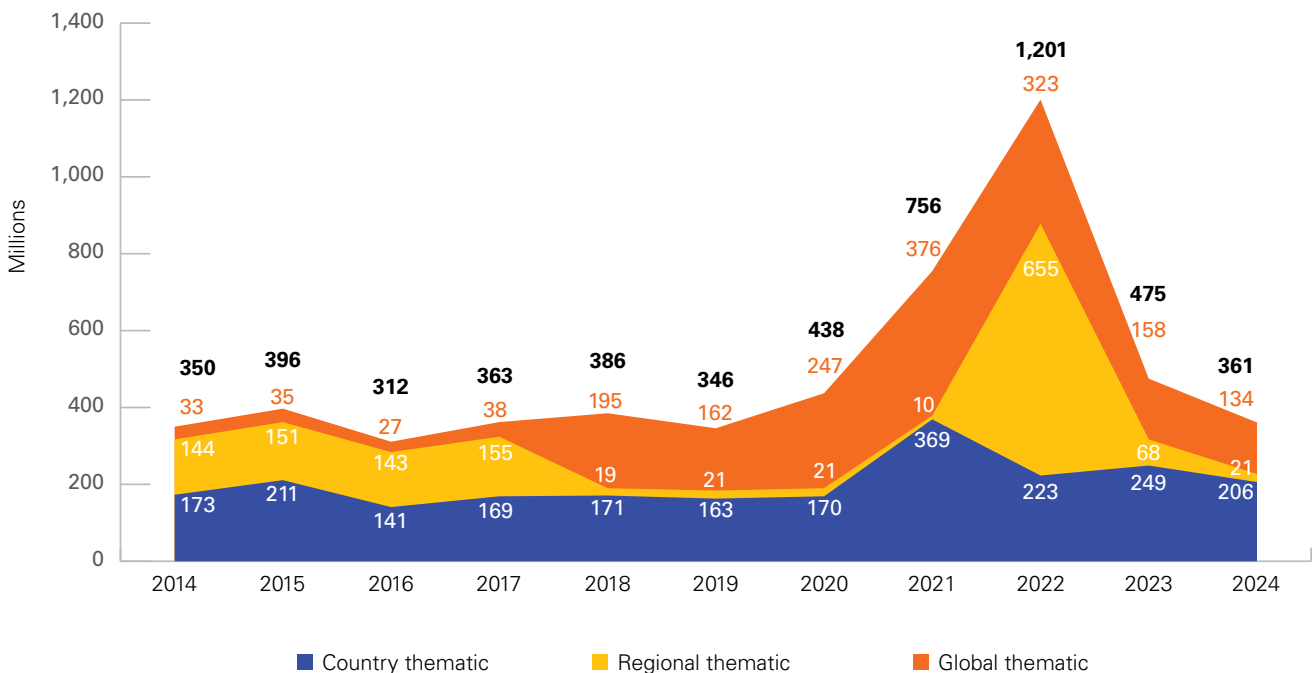


FIGURE A5: OR contributions received by type of funding, 2014-2024: Thematic vs non-thematic



In 2024, 57 per cent (\$206 million) of thematic funding was received through country-level pools, and 37 per cent (\$134 million) through global thematic funding and 6 per cent (\$21 million) through regional thematic funding.

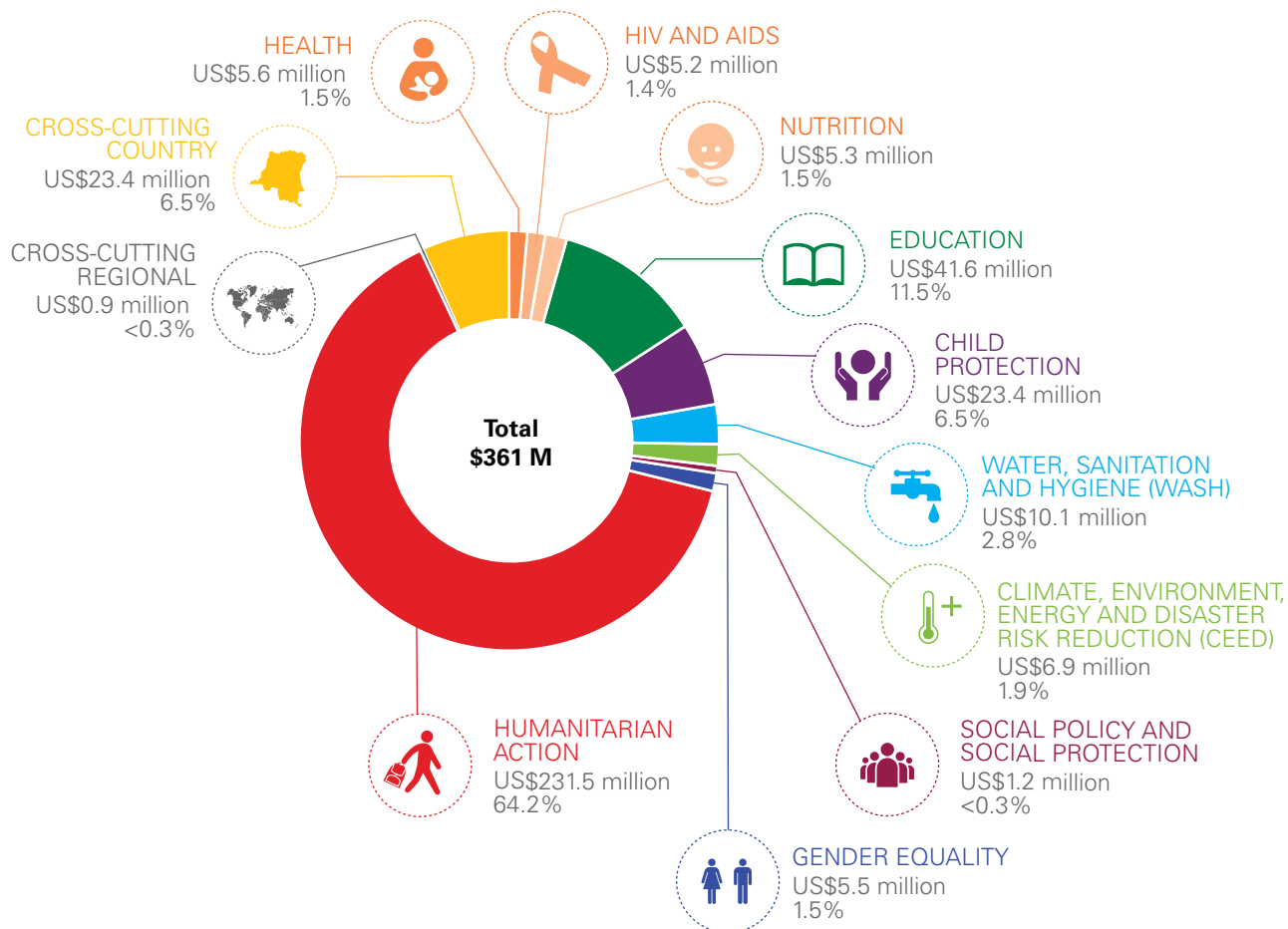
FIGURE A6: Thematic funding contributions received by type, 2014-2024



In 2024, the greatest amount of thematic funding received – 64 per cent – was for UNICEF’s humanitarian response. The increasing trend towards tightly earmarked resources

in development programming erodes the sustainability and predictability UNICEF needs to contribute to long-term impact for children in line with the SDGs.

FIGURE A7: Thematic contributions by funding pool, 2024



Donor Recognition

UNICEF programmes are funded entirely through the voluntary support of millions of people around the world and our partners in government, civil society and the private sector. Voluntary contributions enable UNICEF to deliver on its mandate to protect children’s rights, help meet their basic needs and expand their opportunities to reach their full potential. We take this opportunity to thank all our partners who contributed so generously in 2024 to our work for children around the world.

UNICEF would like to convey special appreciation to partners that have provided thematic contributions. This support enables UNICEF to respond effectively by strengthening systems across priority areas of work and promotes sustainability to achieve the greatest impact for children.

UNICEF’s Strategic Plan 2022-2025 includes the goal of doubling thematic funding as a share of all Other Resources. UNICEF is calling for member states to fulfill their Funding Compact commitment, and for all donors to increase flexible funding as a proportion of their overall portfolio of giving to UNICEF.

In 2024, the top 10 thematic funding resource partners contributed \$240 million, or 67 per cent of the total thematic contributions to UNICEF (see Figure 1). These partners provided 67 per cent of the total thematic funding for UNICEF’s non-humanitarian thematic pools, and 66 per cent of the total humanitarian thematic funding. The top three thematic funding partners in 2024 were Sweden, Denmark and the United States Fund for UNICEF. UNICEF would like to convey its sincere thanks to these partners for their ongoing and steadfast commitment to providing

flexible support to the organization. These three partners alone contributed 33 per cent, or \$119 million, of UNICEF's total thematic funding in 2024.

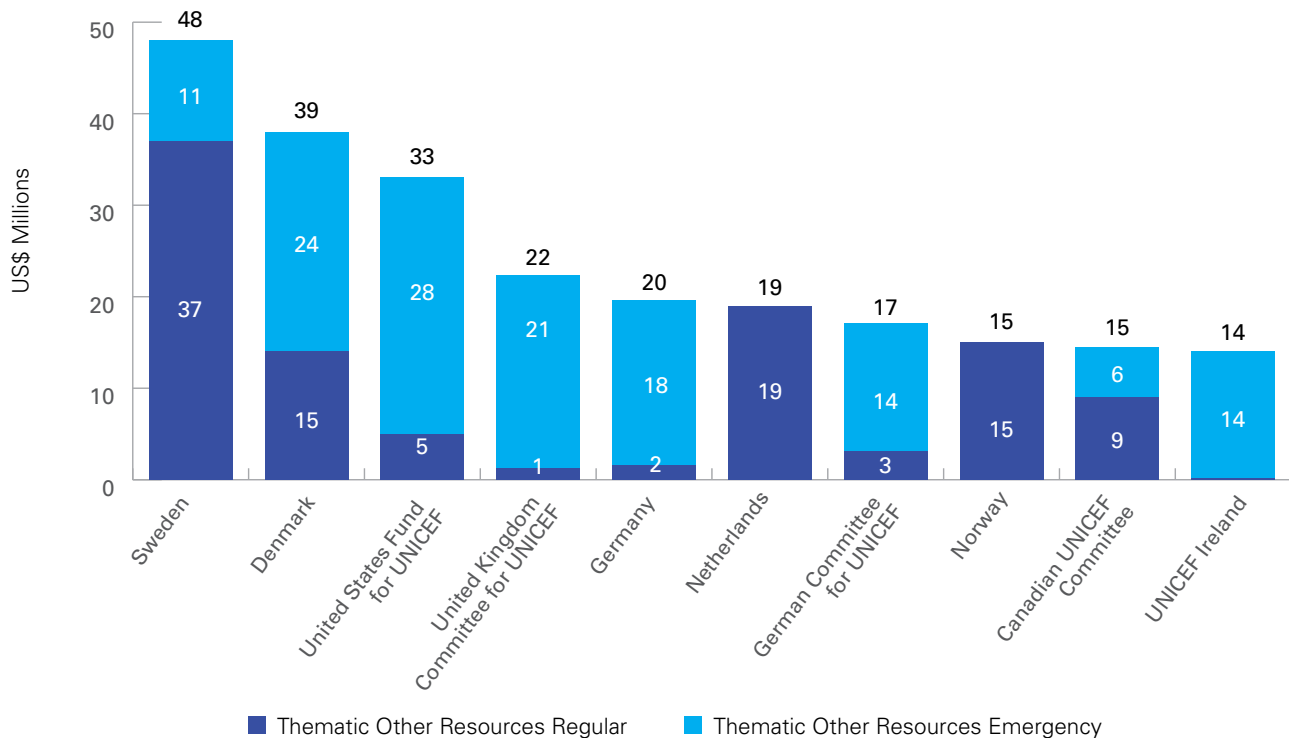
UNICEF would also like to recognize partners who have supported the new thematic modality of Country Programme funding for the UNICEF Strategic Plan 2022-2025. The Country Programme Document (CPD) thematic window, or flexible country window, allows maximum flexibility for UNICEF country offices to address challenges holistically, and supports an integrated approach, funding areas of work that may not be covered under other thematic grants or earmarked funding.

UNICEF is especially grateful to Sweden, a strong advocate and supporter of this modality. In 2024, Sweden remained by far the largest partner for CPD thematic funds, contributing \$10 million (41 % of total contributions to this modality in 2024) to support Country Programmes

in Bangladesh, the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Uganda. Sweden's contributions to CPD thematic funds since the outset of the current Strategic Plan up until 2024 amount to \$48 million (69% of total contributions to this modality).

In addition, UNICEF would like to recognize its private sector partners that are increasingly supporting the flexible country window. In 2024, the CPD thematic window received contributions from ten National Committees, which, together, contributed nearly \$13 million: the Canadian UNICEF Committee, the Committee for UNICEF Switzerland, the United States Fund for UNICEF, the German Committee for UNICEF, the Spanish Committee for UNICEF, the United Kingdom Committee for UNICEF, the Portuguese Committee for UNICEF, the Polish National Committee for UNICEF, French Committee for UNICEF and the Norwegian Committee for UNICEF.

FIGURE A8: Top 10 Resource Partners to Thematic Funding Pools, 2024, by Contributions Received



*Excluding UNICEF Country Office Private Sector Fundraising

Financial Information by Goal Area and/or sectorⁱⁱ

Goal Area 5: Life free of poverty and expanded social protection

In 2024, UNICEF received a total of \$123 million in OR for Goal Area 5, of which development contributions (ORR) made up 61 per cent. Public sector partners contributed the largest share of this funding, at 88 per cent, while private sector partners contributed 12 per cent.

FIGURE A9: Goal Area 5 - OR contributions received by fund type, 2024

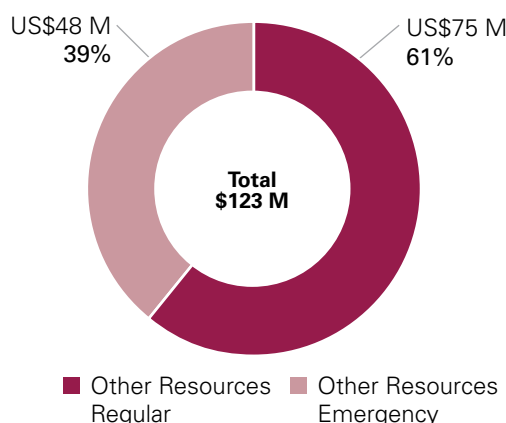
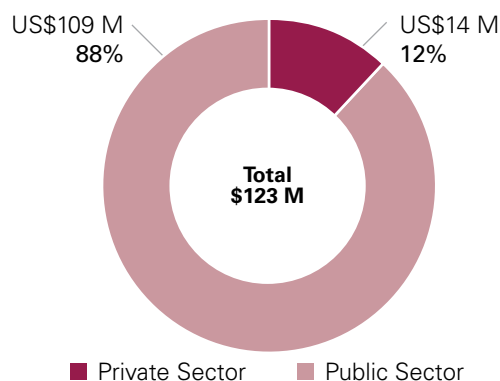


FIGURE A10: Goal Area 5 - OR contributions received by resource partner, 2024



In 2024, Goal Area 5 received a total of \$1 million in thematic contributions, accounting for 1 per cent of total OR contributions. This low proportion has been consistent since 2022, highlighting the urgent need to increase flexible thematic funding for social policy and social protection programmes.

FIGURE A11: Goal Area 5 - OR contributions received by type of funding, 2015–2024: Thematic vs non-thematic

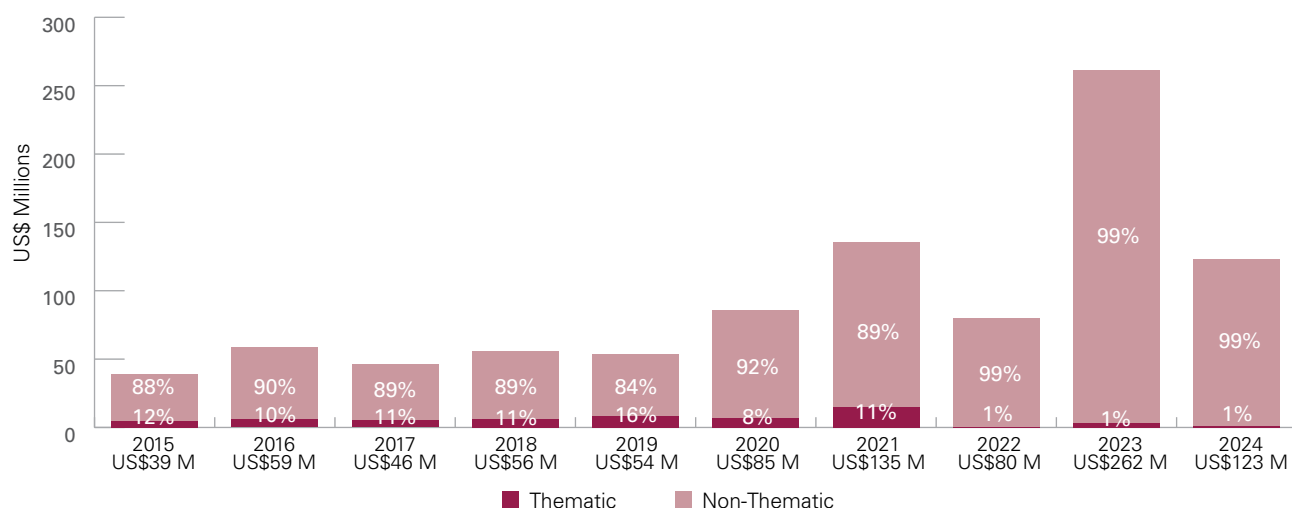


Table A1: Top 20 Resource Partners to Goal Area 5 by Total Contributions in US\$

Rank	Resource Partner	Contributions Received, 2024
1	European Commission	63,639,744
2	Germany	21,698,599
3	United Kingdom Committee for UNICEF	8,811,881
4	World Bank - Washington D.C.	5,673,637
5	UN Multi Partner Trust Fund	5,087,722
6	ILO - International Labour Organization	3,070,896
7	Danish Committee for UNICEF	1,886,884
8	United States Fund for UNICEF	1,864,781
9	Republic of Korea (the)	1,758,000
10	Somalia	1,381,467
11	United States	1,024,646
12	Spanish Committee for UNICEF	809,939
13	Spain	809,061
14	Ireland	787,459
15	Belgium	778,860
16	Kazakhstan	562,440
17	Democratic Republic of the Congo	500,000
18	Committee for UNICEF Switzerland	482,874
19	Australia	417,451
20	UN Joint Programme	262,350

Contributions received from Somalia include \$1 million related to the World Bank. Contributions received from the Democratic Republic of the Congo include \$0.5 million from the World Bank.

TABLE A2: Top 20 Contributions by Grant to Goal Area 5, 2024, in US\$

Rank	Grant Description	Resource Partner	Contributions Received, 2024
1	OPT: Social inclusion € 2.2 M	European Commission / ECHO	45,145,505
2	WCARO: Responding to COVID-19 pandemic through Social Protection Systems	KfW - Germany	15,739,769
3	Lebanon: Social Protection - 20m USD	European Commission/EC	10,154,885
4	WCARO: Responding to COVID-19 pandemic through Social Protection Systems in the Sahel	Germany	5,958,830
5	Yemen: Second Additional Financing for Emergency Social Protection Enhancement and Covid-19 Response Project	World Bank	5,673,637
6	Child Health Advocacy and Communications Phase III-DGCA-Gates	United Kingdom Committee for UNICEF	2,871,287
7	Iraq - Social Protection	European Commission/EC	2,247,147
8	Lesotho: Social Policy - 6,5m USD	European Commission/EC	2,091,232
9	Nigeria: Social Inclusion - 14m USD	European Commission/EC	1,933,826
10	Promoting Playful Parenting and Preventing Abuse and Neglect - DGCA - LEGO	Danish Committee for UNICEF	1,886,884
11	Jordan: Social Protection - Joint Programme with ILO as AA	ILO - International Labour	1,751,568
12	Iraq: Social Inclusion -10M USD	European Commission/EC	1,462,755
13	Somalia: Shock Responsive Safety Net for Human Capital	Somalia	1,381,467
14	PG: Reinforce data management for Humanitarian Cash Transfers	Bureau for Humanitarian Assistance - United States	1,024,533
15	Dominican Republic: Changing Gender Norms for the Prevention of Violence, Child Marriage and Early Unions	Korea International Development Agency - Republic of Korea (the)	1,000,000
16	Child Health Advocacy and Communications Phase III- Bangladesh - Gates	United Kingdom Committee for UNICEF	990,099
17	Child Health Advocacy and Communications Phase III- PG-Gates	United Kingdom Committee for UNICEF	811,881
18	Indonesia: Driving Public and Private Capital Towards Green and Social Investment	UN Multi Partner Trust Fund	809,483
19	GTF Social Policy & Social Protection - Spain	Spain	809,061
20	Malawi: Social Protection For Gender Empowerment and Resilience (SP-Gear) "Amai Titukuke"	Ireland	787,459

Contributions received from Somalia include \$1 million related to the World Bank.

Expenses for Goal Area 5 totalled over \$824 million during 2024 across its two Result Areas. Of this, \$243 million was ORE or 30 per cent of total expenses.

FIGURE A12: Goal Area 5 - Expenses by Result Area, 2024

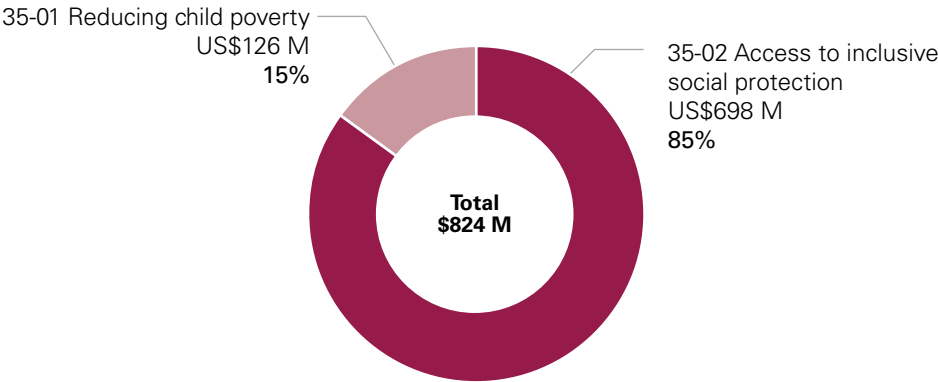
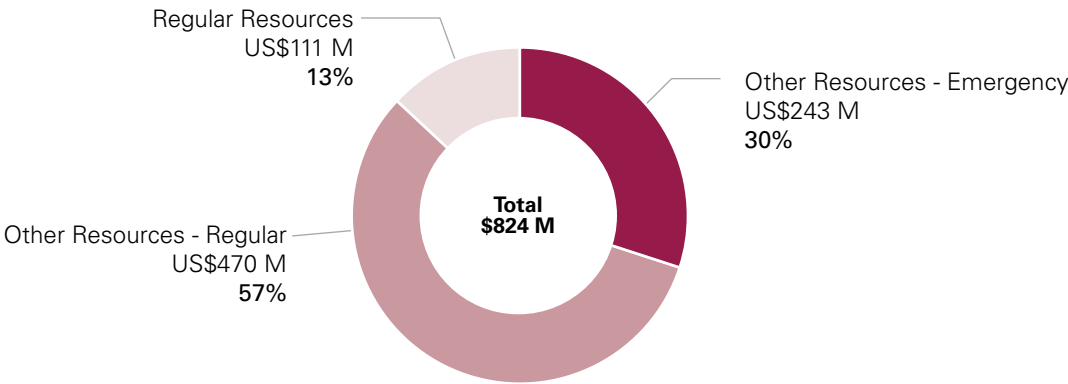


FIGURE A13: Goal Area 5 - Expenses by fund type, 2024



Countries affected by emergencies and protracted humanitarian crises continued to have some of the largest social policy and social protection expenses in 2024. The highest spending was in Yemen (\$220 million), and in the Middle East and North Africa, highlighting ongoing programme needs in those locations.

FIGURE A14: Goal Area 5 Expenses by fund type and top 20 countries, 2024

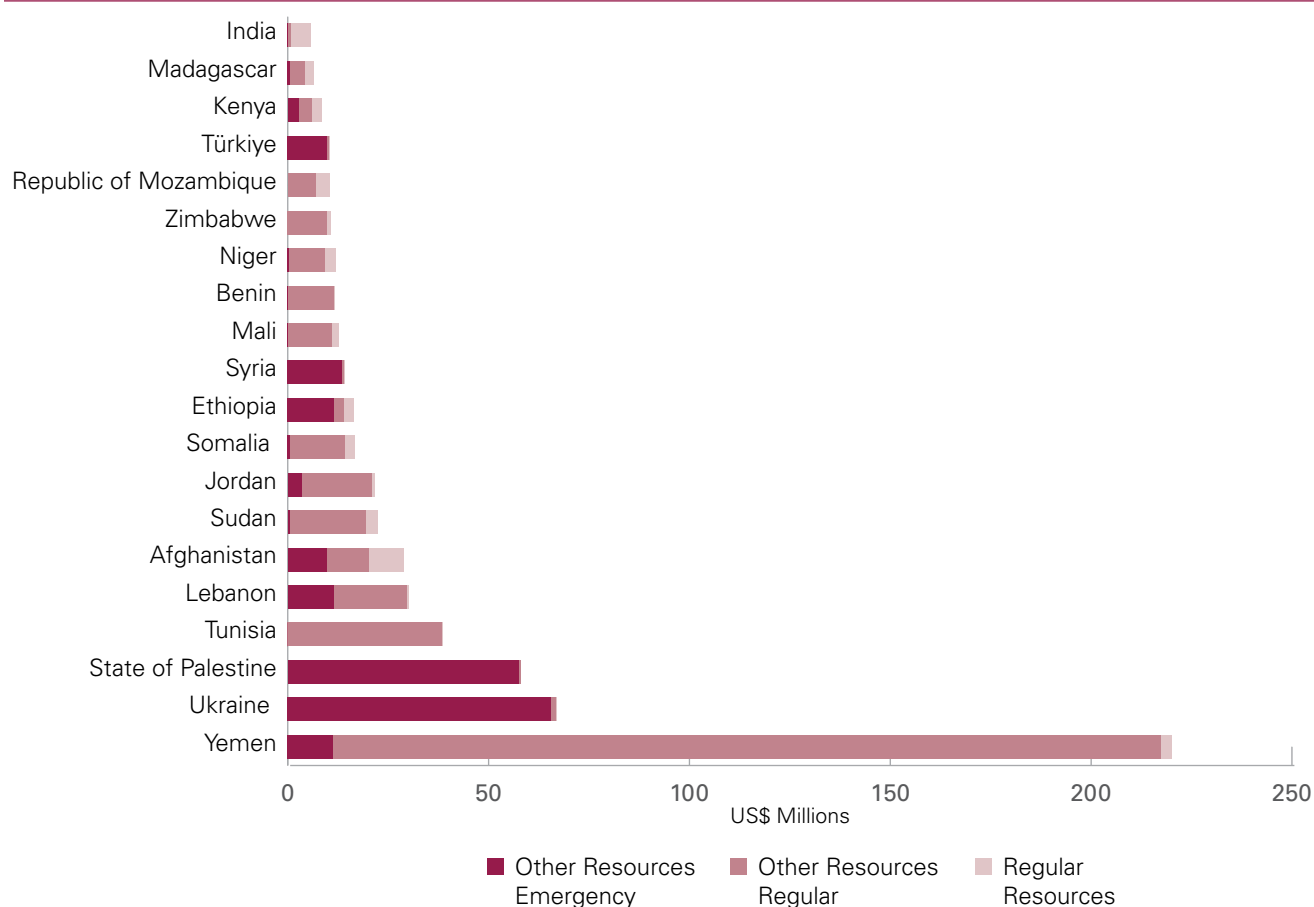
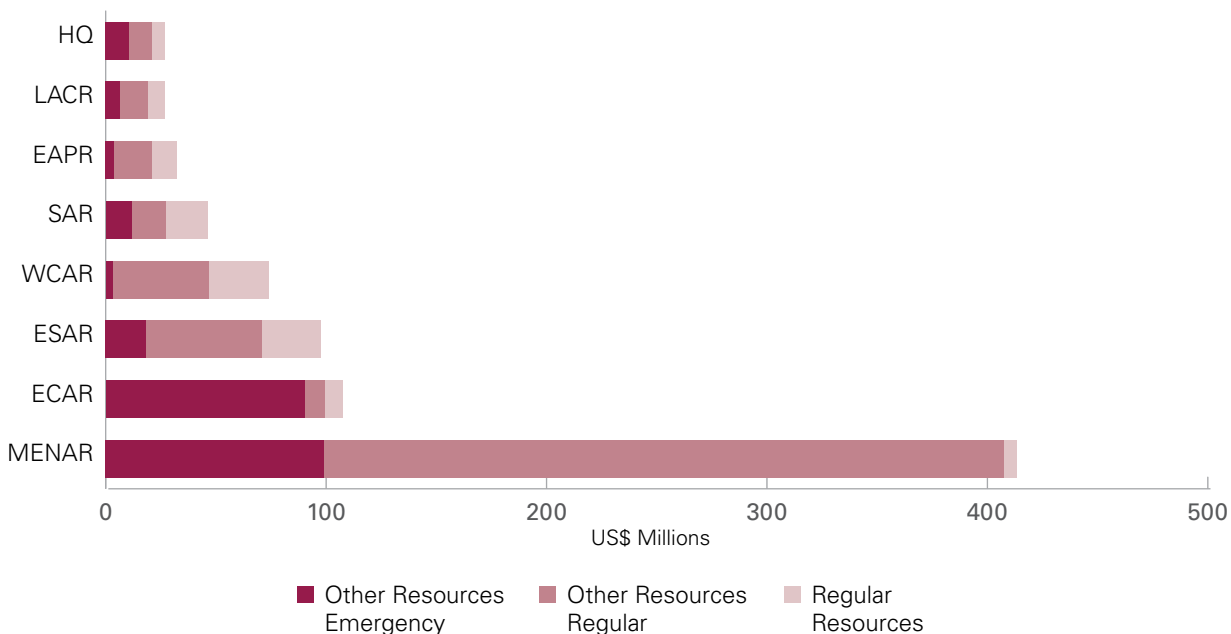


FIGURE A15: Goal Area 5 - Expenses by fund type and region, 2024



i All figures in this chapter have been rounded and may not add up to the totals.

ii Aside from OR contributions received for specific Goal Areas of the Strategic Plan 2022-2025, sectors and gender equality, other OR contributions were received for two or more Goal Areas and/or sectors. In total, \$2.77 billion was received as cross-sectoral OR contributions in 2024, of which 62% was for humanitarian response.



Published by UNICEF
3 United Nations Plaza
New York, NY 10017

www.unicef.org

August 2025

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